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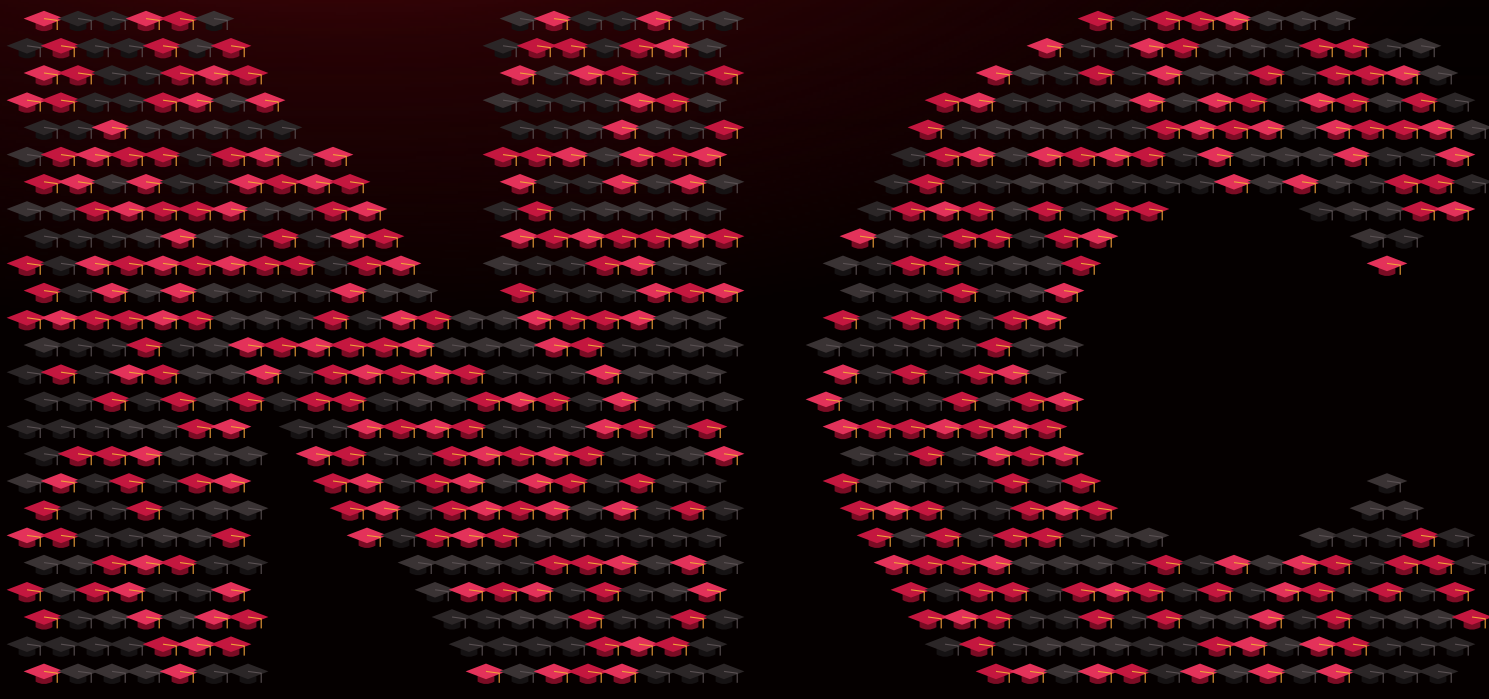
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NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 North Carolina Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **49 in every 100**, mark the international share of North Carolina's STEM master's degrees.



The 2026 North Carolina Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 18
Section 3 Where Students Come From 24
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 30
Section 5 Graduate Research 32
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 34
Section 7 Research Funding 36
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 38
Section 9 STEM Workforce 42
Section 10 Patents 44
Section 11 Competitors 46
Section 12 Fields of Study 48
Section 13 Students and Money 58
Section 14 Student Outcomes 66
Section 15 Faculty 70
Section 16 Institutions 74

BACK MATTER

About these Data 78
By the Numbers 80
Sources 89

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Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to North Carolina: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

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Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, and from SEVIS by the Numbers, published by the Department of Homeland Security's Student and Exchange Visitor Program. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 North Carolina Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What North Carolina's numbers say

1. **International students earn 49% of North Carolina's STEM master's degrees,** 3.1 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 20th of 51 on dependence. The share is 39% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 4.3% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **North Carolina awarded 2.42K STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 2.1% of the U.S. total and 17th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed +94%, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in engineering technology,** where international students earned 66% of master's degrees (533 degrees; U.S. 54%). 2 STEM fields with at least 50 master's graduates are majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** North Carolina ranks 3rd of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: North Carolina 49%, Virginia 39%, Georgia 44%, Ohio 58%, Pennsylvania 54%.
5. **79% of North Carolina's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 1.7% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (16K) than residents left (12.8K), a net gain of 3.2K; the top destination for those leaving was Virginia.

49%

of the STEM master's degrees North Carolina awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

582K #10
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +3.4% since 2015

2.42K #17
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · +94% since 2015

49% #20
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +11.4 pp since 2015

14% #24
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +1.8 pp since 2015

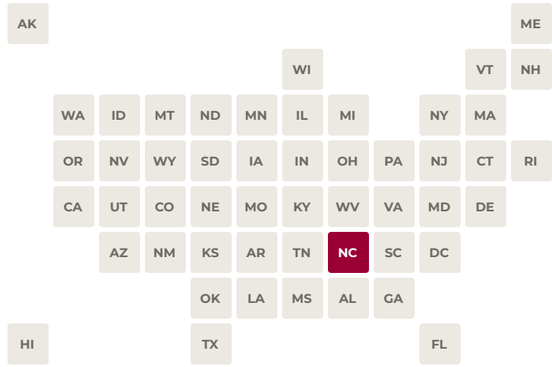
26% #13
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +6.4 pp since 2015

66% #22
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +5.0 pp since 2015

$15.6K #9
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +12% since 2015

79% #11
First-time students from in state, 2024
U.S. **–** · −3.0 pp since 2016

$95.1K #28
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −6.3% since 2016

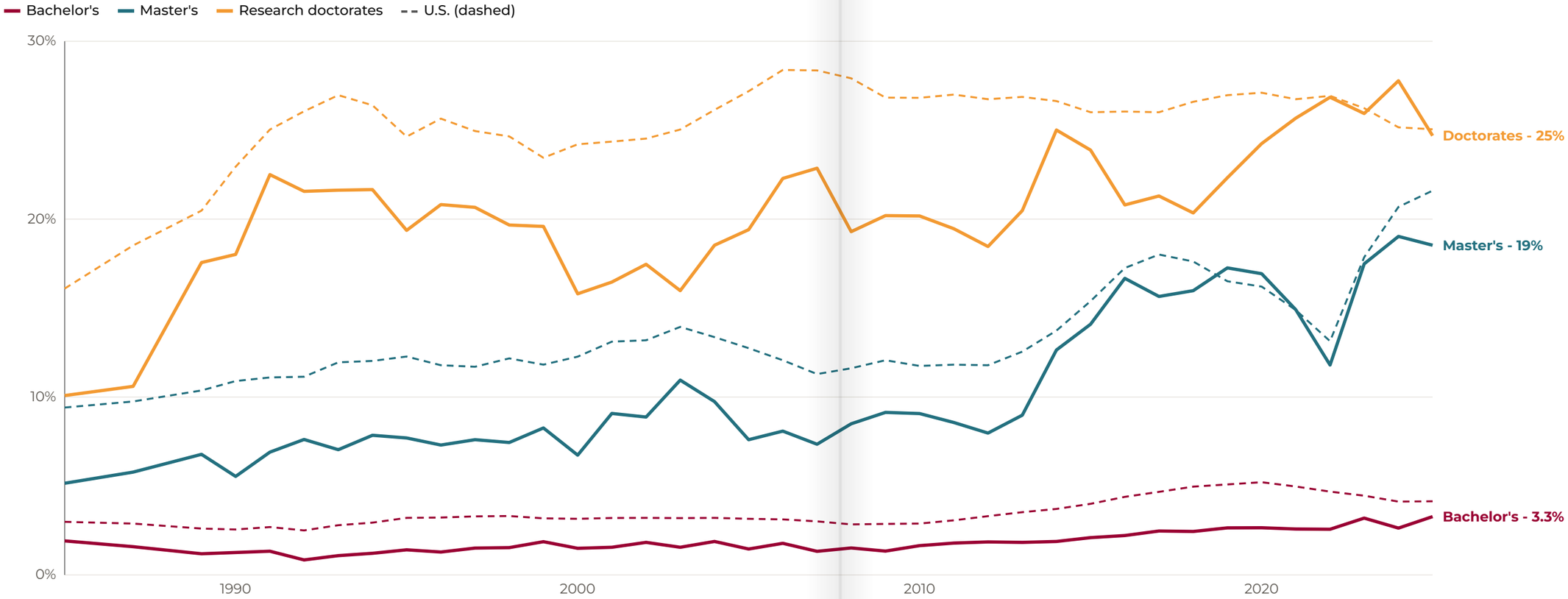


Badges give North Carolina's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Figure 1 What Share of North Carolina's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 14% of North Carolina's graduate enrollment and 2.1% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 3.3% of bachelor's, 19% of master's and 25% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 4.3% of STEM bachelor's, 49% of STEM master's and 39% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 2.1% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 17th of 51.

14%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **24th** of 51 · +1.8 pp since 2015

19%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

U.S. **22%** · **21st** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

49%

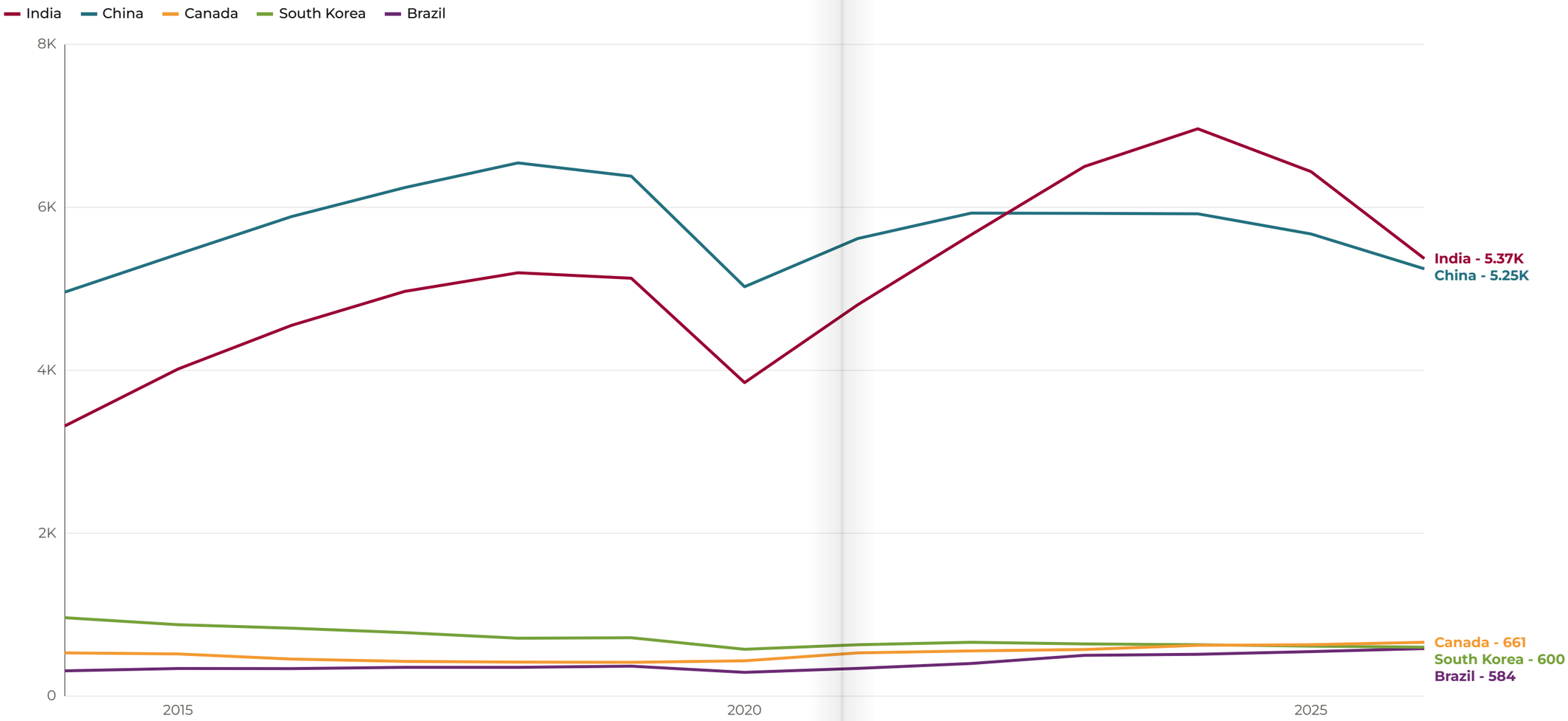
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **20th** of 51 · +11.4 pp since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 2 Where Do North Carolina's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one snapshot per year (the latest month available), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, North Carolina had 23.2K active international students in SEVIS, 16th of 51. India accounted for 23% of them and China for 23%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

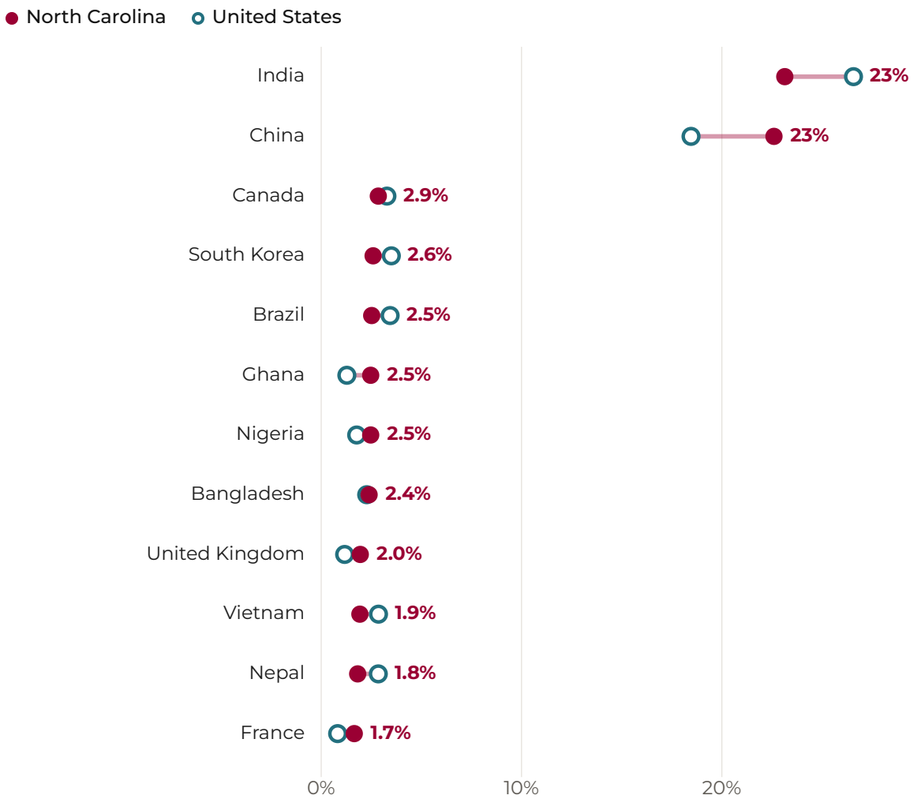
Students came from 183 countries, but the two largest supplied 46%. The state's total is up 32% since 2014.

23.2K
Active international students, October 2026
16th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

23%
From India
U.S. **27%**

76%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

Figure 3 Is North Carolina's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

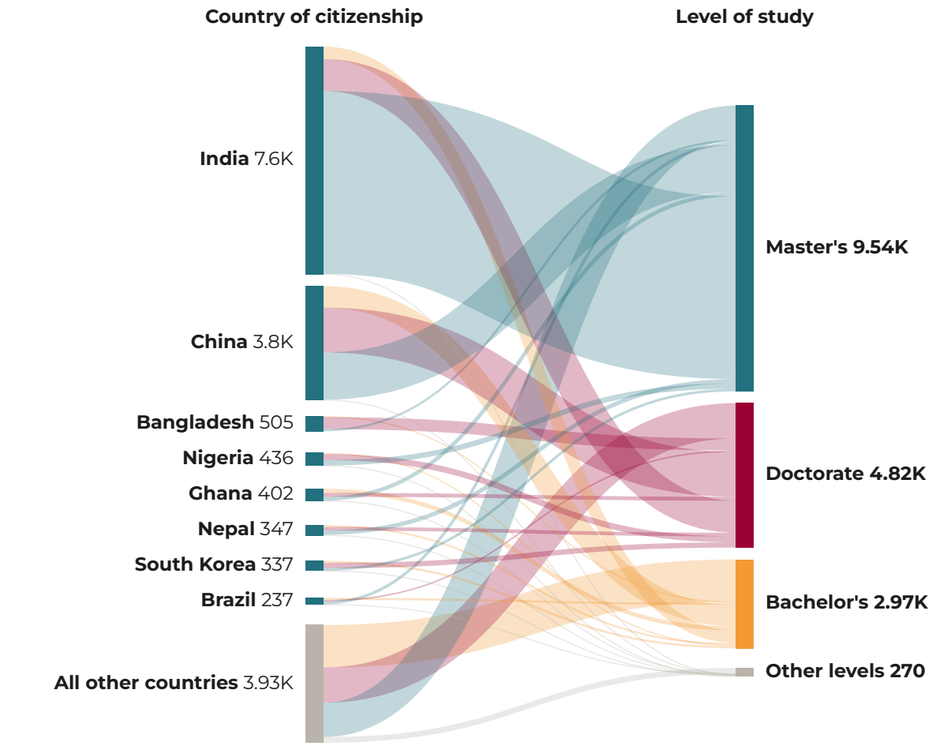
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is one of the 12 countries with the most active F-1 and M-1 student records in North Carolina in October 2026. The filled dot is the country's share of the state's international students; the open dot is its share of all international students in the United States. Students at every level, from secondary school to doctorate, are counted. Yearly counts are the latest month available in each year.

THE NUMBERS

- **All active international students**: 23.2K in October 2026, 16th of 51 states (U.S. 1.19M), down 6.2% from 24.8K in 2025, and up 22% since 2015 (19K).
- **India**: 23% of the state's international students (U.S. 27%); 5.37K students in 2026, down 17% from 6.44K in 2025, and up 34% since 2015 (4.02K).
- **China**: 23% of the state's international students (U.S. 18%); 5.25K students in 2026, down 7.5% from 5.67K in 2025, and down 3.3% since 2015 (5.43K).
- **Canada**: 2.9% of the state's international students (U.S. 3.3%); 661 students in 2026, up 4.9% from 630 in 2025, and up 28% since 2015 (517).

Figure 4 Which Countries Supply North Carolina's International STEM Students?



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level, October 2026; the eight largest countries. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

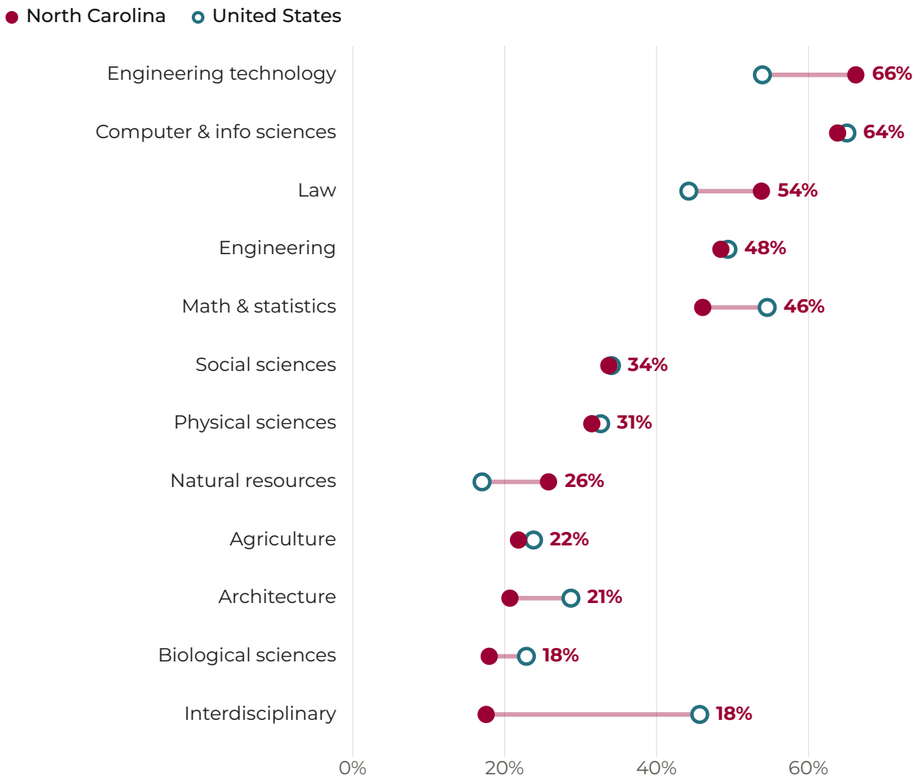
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each band runs from a country of citizenship on the left to a level of study on the right, for international students enrolled in STEM fields in October 2026. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. The eight largest countries are shown and the rest are grouped as all other countries.

THE NUMBERS

- **Share of international students in STEM fields**: 76% in October 2026 (U.S. 63%).
- **Master's level**: 9.54K students; largest countries India (6.1K), China (1.58K), Nigeria (180).
- **Doctorate level**: 4.82K students; largest countries China (1.5K), India (1.07K), Bangladesh (400).
- **Bachelor's level**: 2.97K students; largest countries China (717), India (413), Ghana (139).
- **Active STEM students**: 17.6K in 2026 (U.S. 749K; 14th of 51 states), down 4.4% from 18.4K in 2025, and up 89% since 2015 (9.29K).
- **Share of STEM master's students from India**: 64% in 2026 (U.S. 58%; 18th of 51 states), down 1.2 points from 65% in 2025, and down 2.9 points since 2015 (67%).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in North Carolina in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest international shares**: engineering technology 66% (U.S. 54%); computer & info sciences 64% (U.S. 65%); law 54% (U.S. 44%).
- **All master's degrees**: 19% in 2025 (U.S. 22%; 21st of 51 states), down 0.5 points from 19% in 2024, and up 4.4 points since 2015 (14%).
- **STEM master's degrees**: 49% in 2025 (U.S. 52%; 20th of 51 states), down 1.7 points from 51% in 2024, and up 11.4 points since 2015 (38%).
- **Computer and information sciences master's**: 64% in 2025 (U.S. 65%; 25th of 47 states), up 0.3 points from 64% in 2024, and up 16.3 points since 2015 (48%).

Table 1 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	6.4% / 8.6%	**64% / 65%**	64% / 56%
Engineering	4.2% / 7.2%	**48% / 49%**	54% / 55%
Engineering technology	1.3% / 4.5%	**66% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	14% / 17%	**46% / 55%**	47% / 53%
Physical sciences	2.5% / 6.0%	**31% / 33%**	33% / 38%
Biological sciences	2.6% / 3.4%	**18% / 23%**	18% / 23%
Natural resources	1.3% / 2.0%	**26% / 17%**	30% / 27%
Architecture	1.2% / 7.3%	**21% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in North Carolina / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

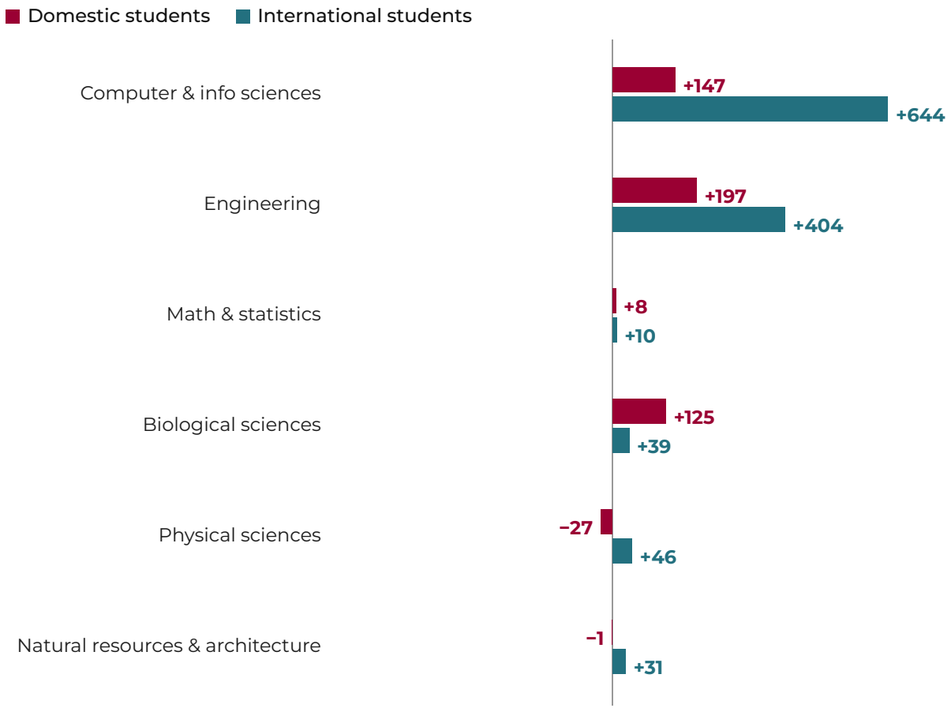
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: North Carolina first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest international share among STEM master's fields**: engineering technology, 66% (U.S. 54%).
- **STEM fields where international students earn a majority of master's degrees**: 2.
- **International share of STEM bachelor's**: 4.3% in 2025 (U.S. 6.6%; 33rd of 51 states), up 0.9 points from 3.4% in 2024, and up 1.0 point since 2015 (3.2%).
- **International share of STEM master's**: 49% in 2025 (U.S. 52%; 20th of 51 states), down 1.7 points from 51% in 2024, and up 11.4 points since 2015 (38%).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 39% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 30th of 51 states), down 4.7 points from 44% in 2024, and up 1.0 point since 2015 (38%).

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in North Carolina between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

THE NUMBERS

- **STEM master's degrees**: 4.94K in 2025, against 3.32K in 2015: +1.17K for international students and +449 for domestic students.
- **Computer & info sciences**: +147 for domestic students and +644 for international students.
- **Engineering**: +197 for domestic students and +404 for international students.
- **Math & statistics**: +8 for domestic students and +10 for international students.
- **International students' STEM master's degrees**: 2.42K in 2025 (U.S. 117K; 17th of 51 states), down 2.5% from 2.48K in 2024, and up 94% since 2015 (1.25K).

Table 2 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	854	**1.65K**	+93%	1.05K	48%	64%
Engineering	1.2K	**1.8K**	+50%	968	47%	54%
Math & statistics	249	**267**	+7.2%	123	45%	46%
Biological sciences	376	**540**	+44%	97	15%	18%
Physical sciences	232	**251**	+8.2%	79	14%	31%
Natural resources & architecture	406	**436**	+7.4%	105	18%	24%

STEM master's degrees awarded in North Carolina, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in North Carolina in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

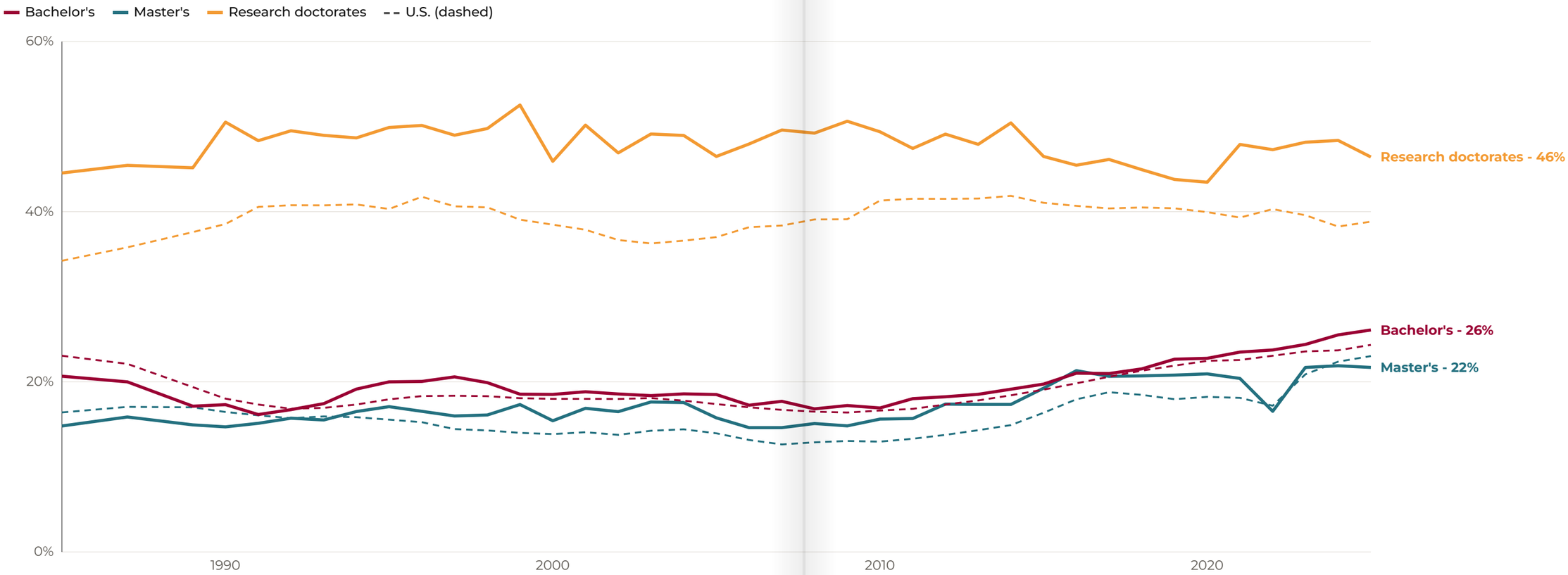
THE NUMBERS

- **STEM share of master's degrees**: 22% in 2025 (U.S. 23%; 24th of 51 states), down 0.2 points from 22% in 2024, and up 2.4 points since 2015 (19%).
- **Share of all U.S. international STEM master's**: 2.1% in 2025 (17th of 51 states), down 0.2 points from 2.3% in 2024, and down 0.3 points since 2015 (2.3%).
- **STEM master's degrees per research doctorate**: 4.1 in 2025 (U.S. 6.4; 37th of 51 states), up 0.2 from 3.9 in 2024, and up 0.8 since 2015 (3.3).

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Figure 7 How Much of North Carolina's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 26% of North Carolina's bachelor's degrees, 22% of its master's and 46% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 2.4 points since 2015, and the state ranks 24th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 13th of 51.

26%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **13th** of 51 · +6.4 pp since 2015

22%

STEM share of master's, 2025

U.S. **23%** · **24th** of 51 · +2.4 pp since 2015

46%

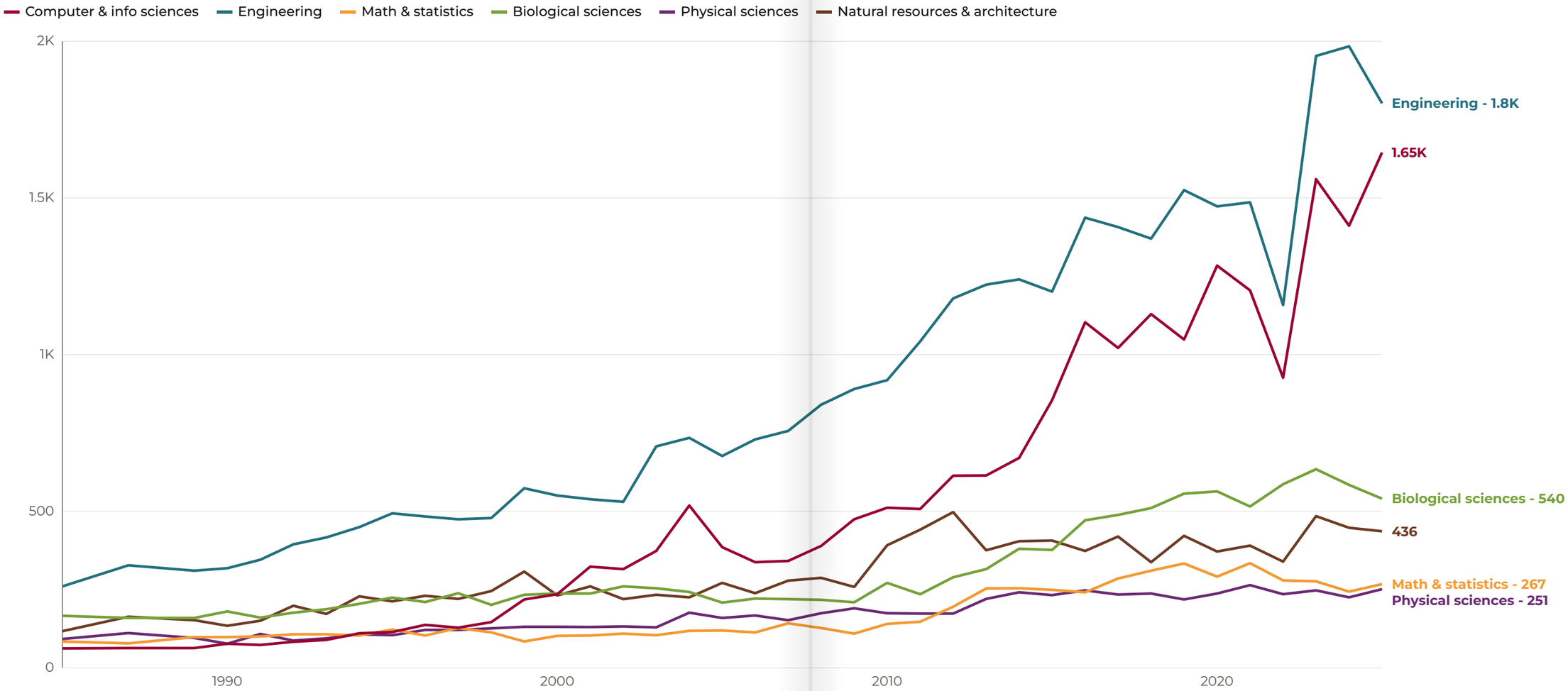
STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **14th** of 51 · −0.1 pp since 2015

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NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce North Carolina's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Engineering produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.8K, followed by computer & info sciences (1.65K) and biological sciences (540). Master's degrees in engineering are up 50% since 2015.

International students earned 2.42K of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 2.1% of the national total (17th of 51).

2.42K

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **17th** of 51 · +94% since 2015

2.1%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **100%** · **17th** of 51 · −0.3 pp since 2015

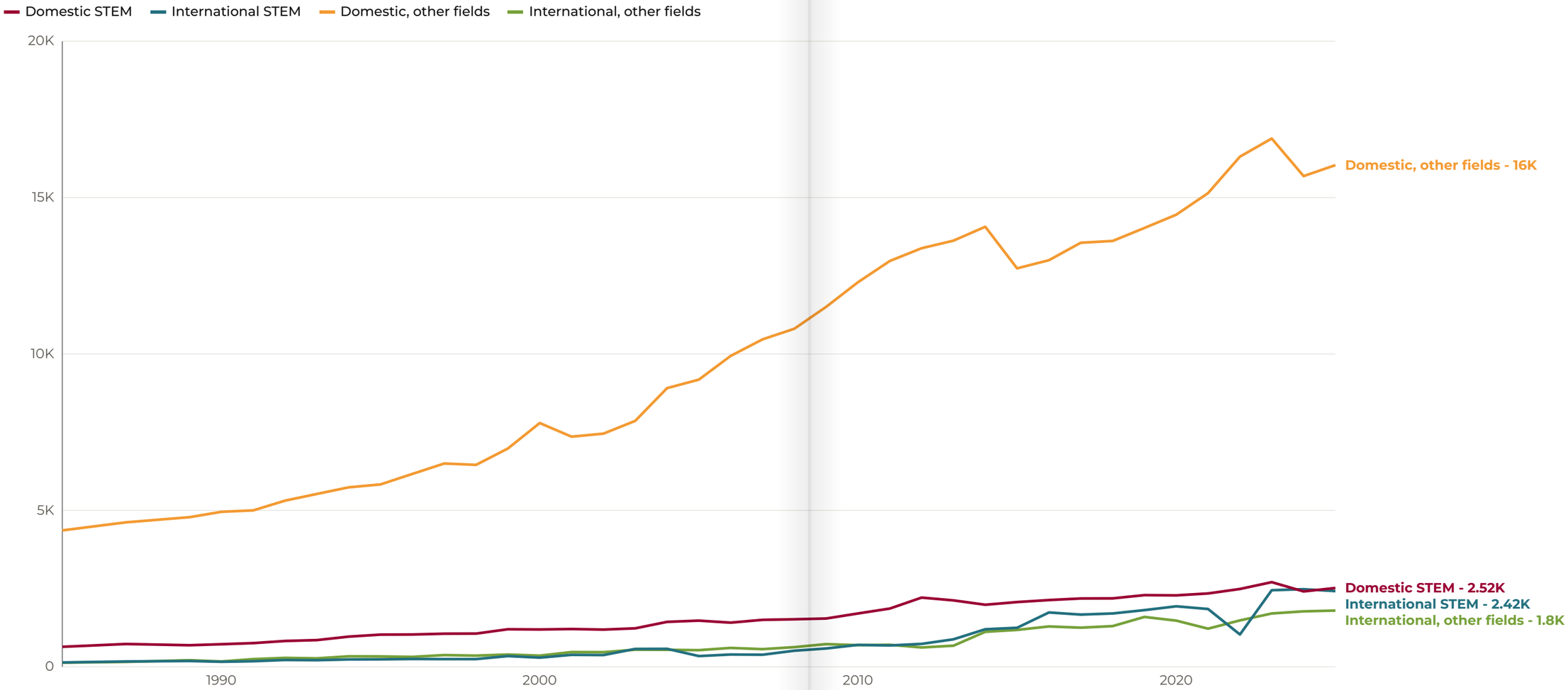
64%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **25th** of 47 · +16.3 pp since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 9 Who Earns North Carolina's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 1.17K more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 449 more to domestic students.

International students earn 49% of North Carolina's STEM master's but 10% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

19%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

U.S. **22%** · **21st** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

49%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **20th** of 51 · +11.4 pp since 2015

4.1

STEM master's per doctorate, 2025

U.S. **6.4** · **37th** of 51 · +0.8 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations, the rest grouped. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

69.7K residents stayed in North Carolina for college in fall 2024; 16K students arrived from other states and 1.52K from abroad, while 12.8K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 79% of the state's first-time students are residents (U.S. –).

79%
First-time students from in state, 2024
· **11th** of 51 · −3.0 pp since 2016

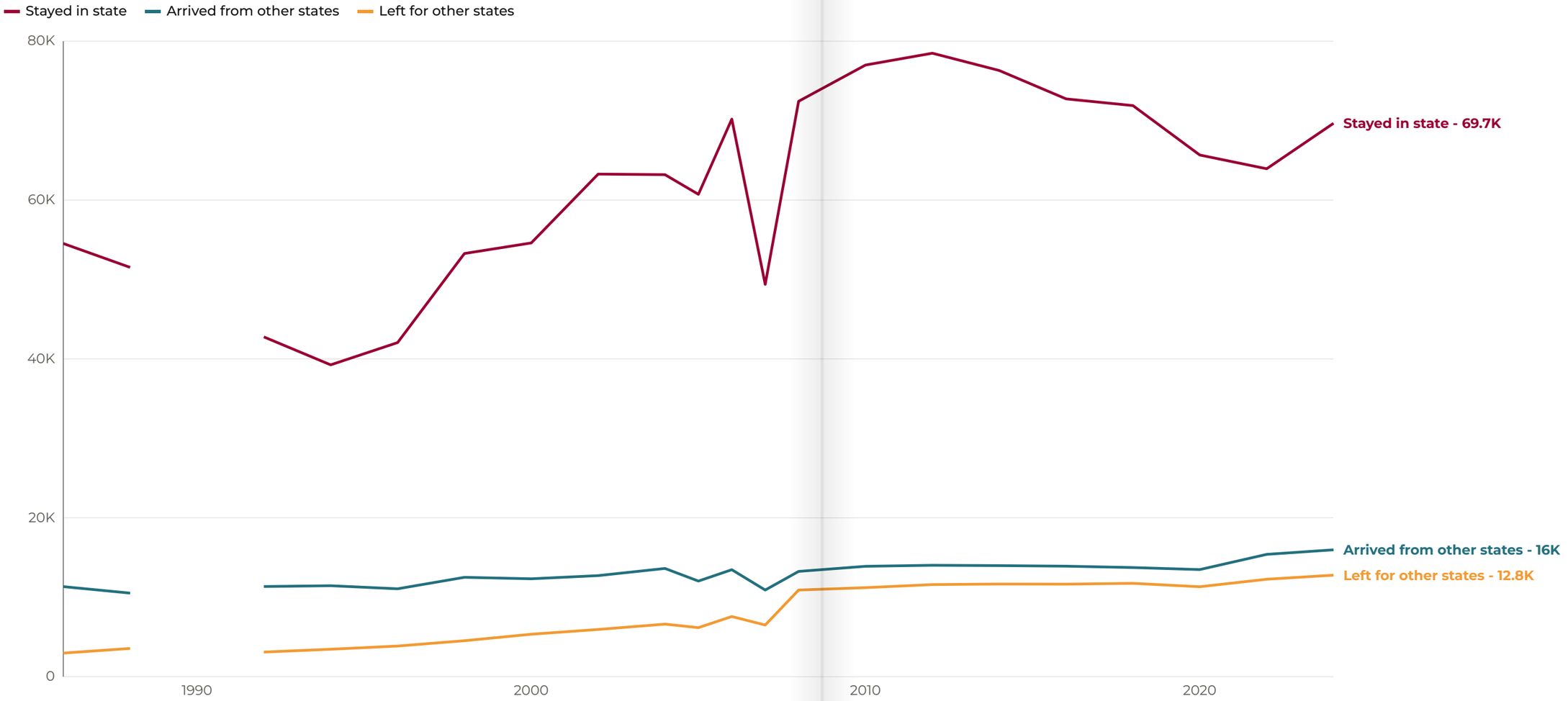
1.7%
First-time students from abroad, 2024
U.S. **3.1%** · **39th** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2016

+4
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
· **29th** of 51 · +1.2 since 2016

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?

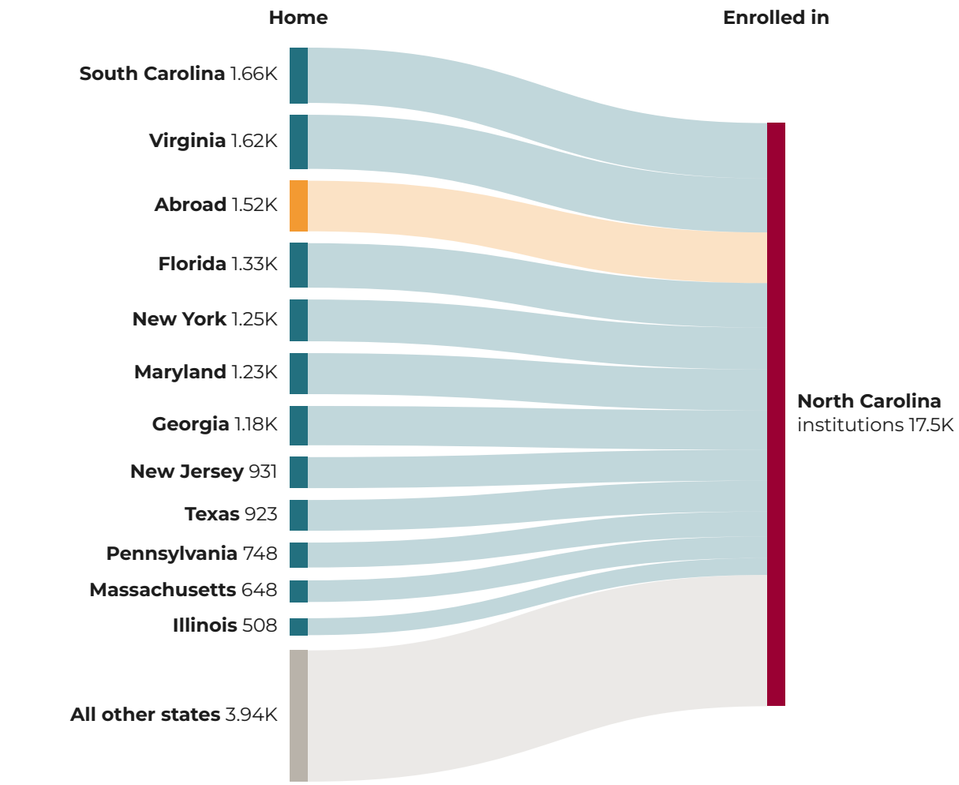


First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is down 4%, arrivals from other states are up 15%, and residents leaving are up 10%.

Net migration was +4 per 100 resident first-time students (29th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Virginia (1.96K).

Figure 12 Where Do North Carolina's Newcomers Come From?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

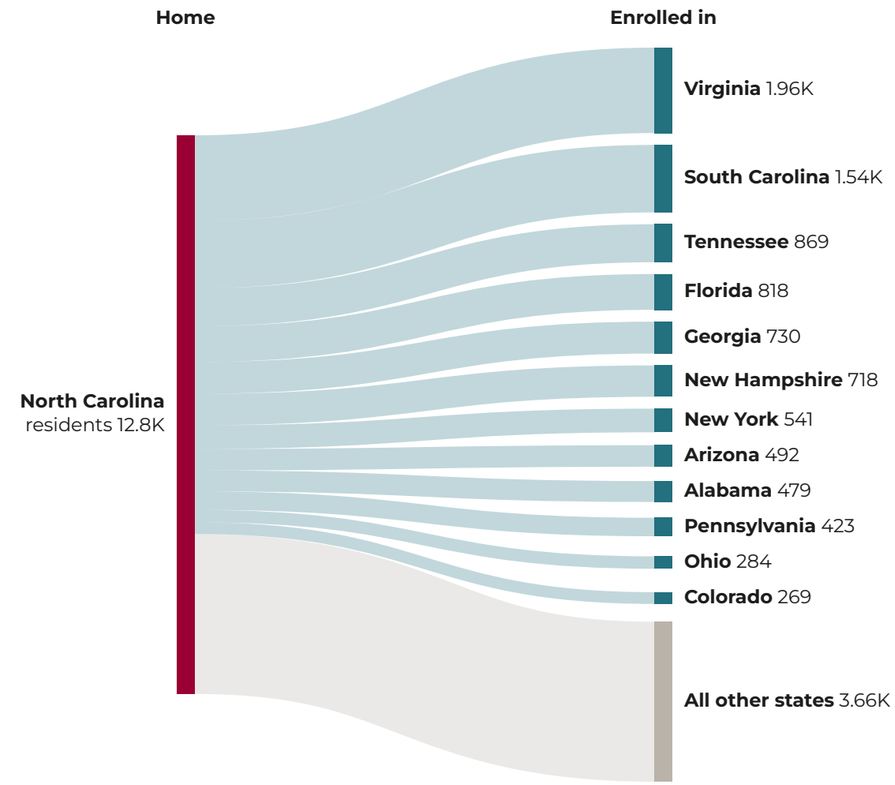
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at North Carolina's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

THE NUMBERS

- **Students arriving from other states**: 16K in fall 2024, up 3.8% from 15.4K in fall 2022, and up 15% since fall 2016 (13.9K).
- **Students arriving from abroad**: 1.52K in fall 2024.
- **Largest home states**: South Carolina (1.66K), Virginia (1.62K), Florida (1.33K).
- **Share of first-time students from outside the U.S.**: 1.7% in 2024 (U.S. 3.1%; 39th of 51 states), down 0.2 points from 2.0% in 2022, and up 0.2 points since 2016 (1.6%).

Figure 13 Where Do North Carolina's Residents Go When They Leave?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The bands show where North Carolina residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

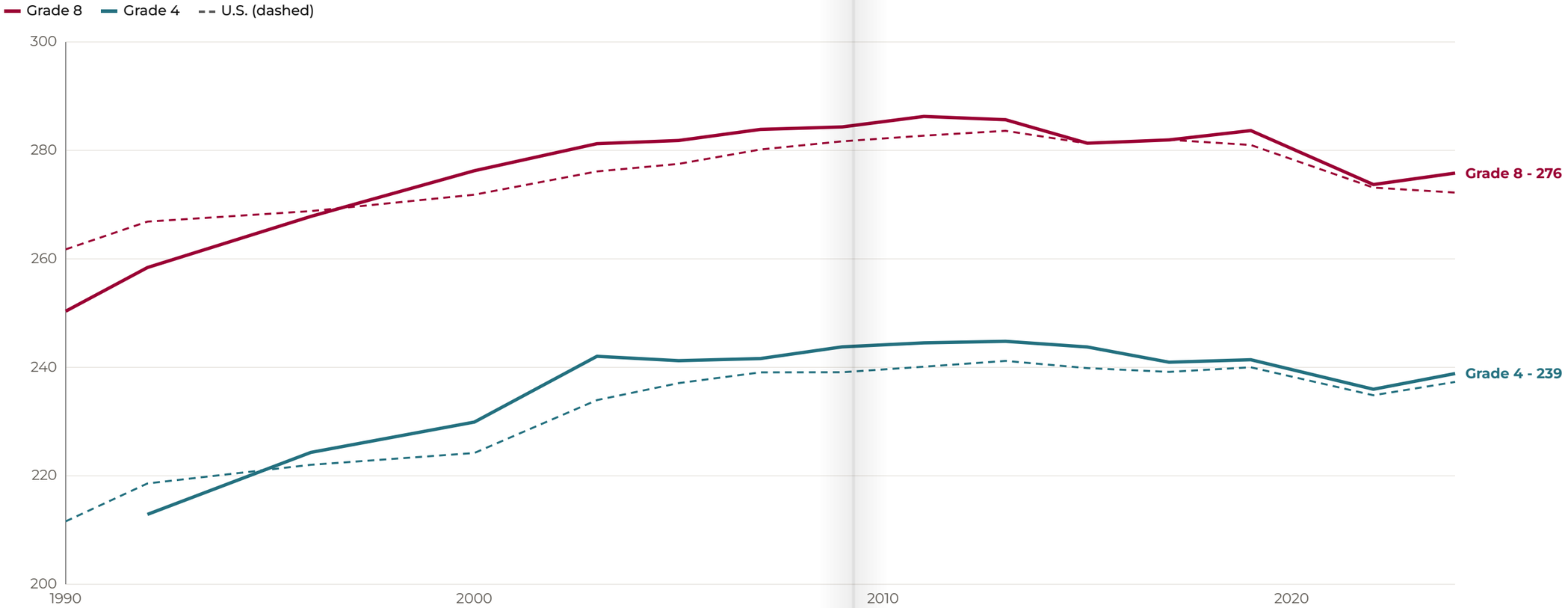
THE NUMBERS

- **Residents leaving for other states**: 12.8K in fall 2024, up 4.1% from 12.3K in fall 2022, and up 9.7% since fall 2016 (11.7K).
- **Residents staying in the state**: 69.7K in fall 2024, up 9.0% from 63.9K in fall 2022, and down 4.2% since fall 2016 (72.7K).
- **Largest destinations**: Virginia (1.96K), South Carolina (1.54K), Tennessee (869).
- **Net migration per 100 resident first-time students**: +4 in 2024 (29th of 51 states), down 0 from +4 in 2022, and up 1 since 2016 (+3).

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are North Carolina's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. North Carolina's eighth graders averaged 276 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 20th of 51 among the states.

31% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

276

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **20th** of 51 · −5.5 since 2015

31%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **14th** of 51 · −1.1 pp since 2015

255

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

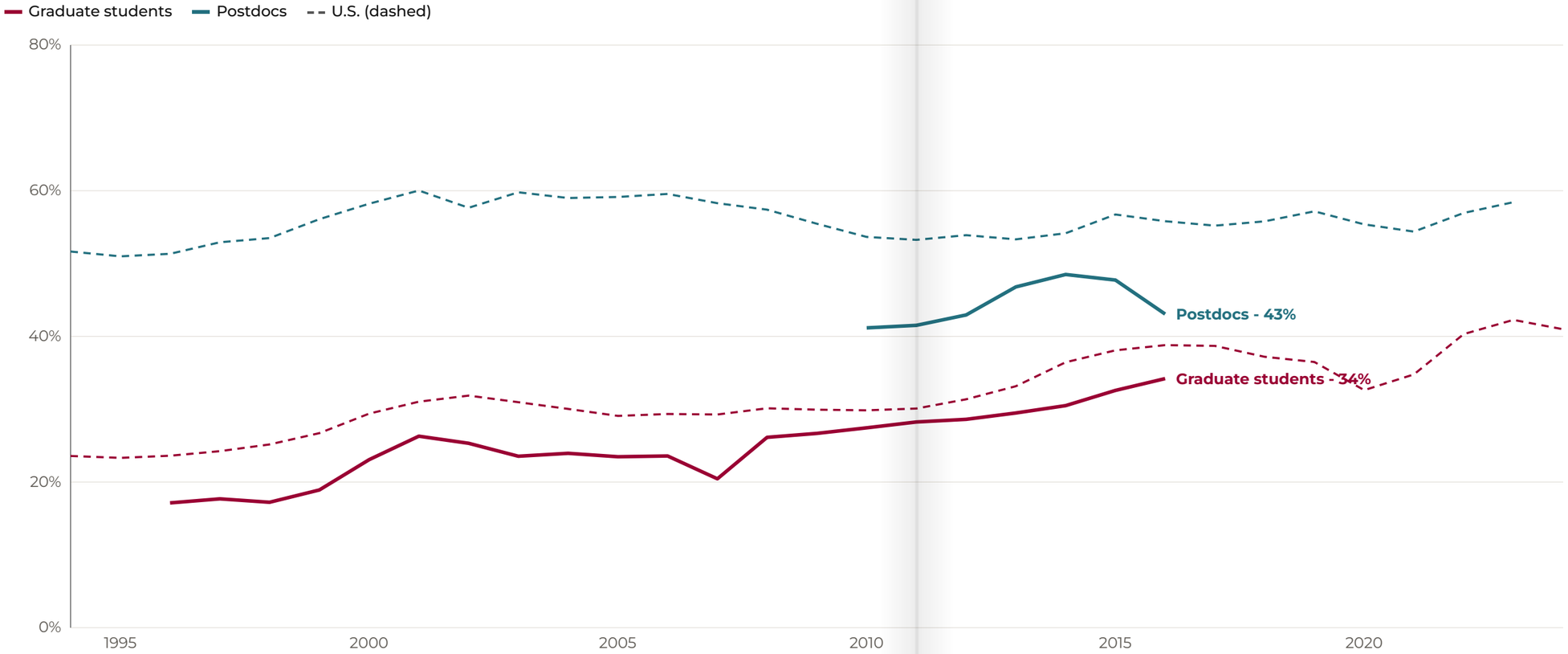
U.S. **257** · **35th** of 51 · −5.7 since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Figure 15 How Many of North Carolina's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 34% of North Carolina's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 25th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 43% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 1.97K research doctorates in 2025, 3.3% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

34%
S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **39%** · **25th** of 51 · +1.6 pp since 2015

43%
S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **56%** · **43rd** of 51 · −4.7 pp since 2015

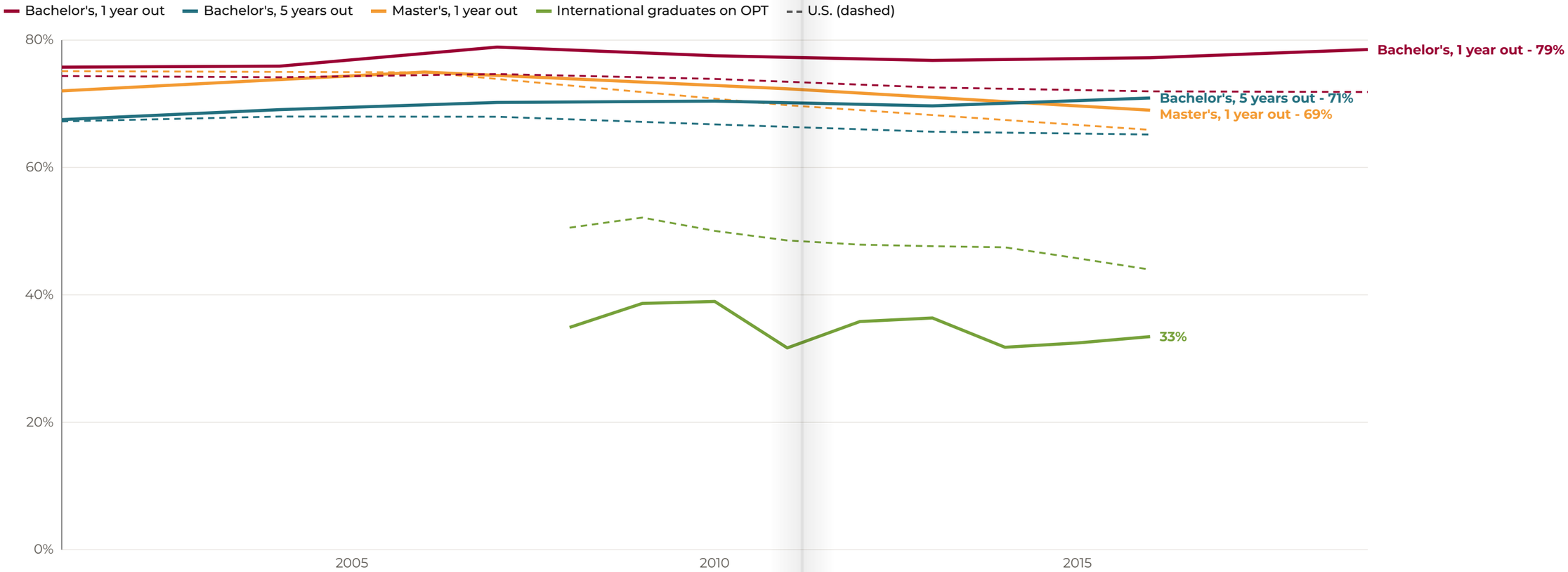
1.97K
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025
U.S. **59K** · **8th** of 51 · +15% since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Figure 16 How Many of North Carolina's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Of North Carolina's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 79% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 71%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 33% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). Through migration between states, the state gained 5.4 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

79%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **4th** of 33 · +1.3 pp since 2016

33%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **30th** of 51 · +1.0 pp since 2015

+5.4

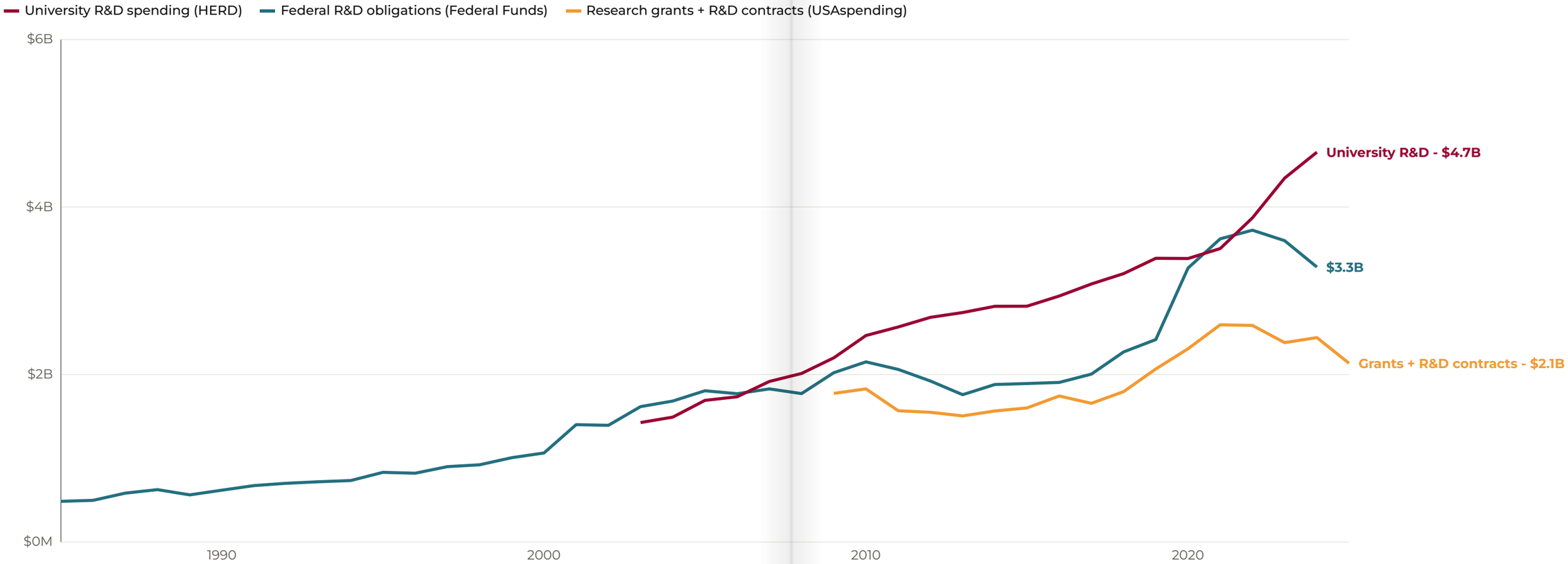
Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

· **11th** of 51 · −5.9 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into North Carolina?



Millions of nominal dollars, fiscal years. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

North Carolina's universities spent $4.65B on research and development in FY2024, 7th of 51 among the states; 59% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $3.28B for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$4.65B
University R&D spending, 2024
U.S. **$118B** · **7th** of 51 · +65% since 2015

59%
Federal share of university R&D, 2024
U.S. **55%** · **14th** of 51 · +1.9 pp since 2015

$3.28B
Federal R&D obligations, 2024
U.S. **$193B** · **17th** of 51 · +74% since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does North Carolina Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 29.3K H-1B positions at North Carolina worksites in FY2025, 7th of 51 among the states. A labor certification comes before the petition, so this overstates hires; USCIS approved 3.12K new H-1B petitions from employers in the state in FY2026.

DOL certified 3.77K PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 6.6% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

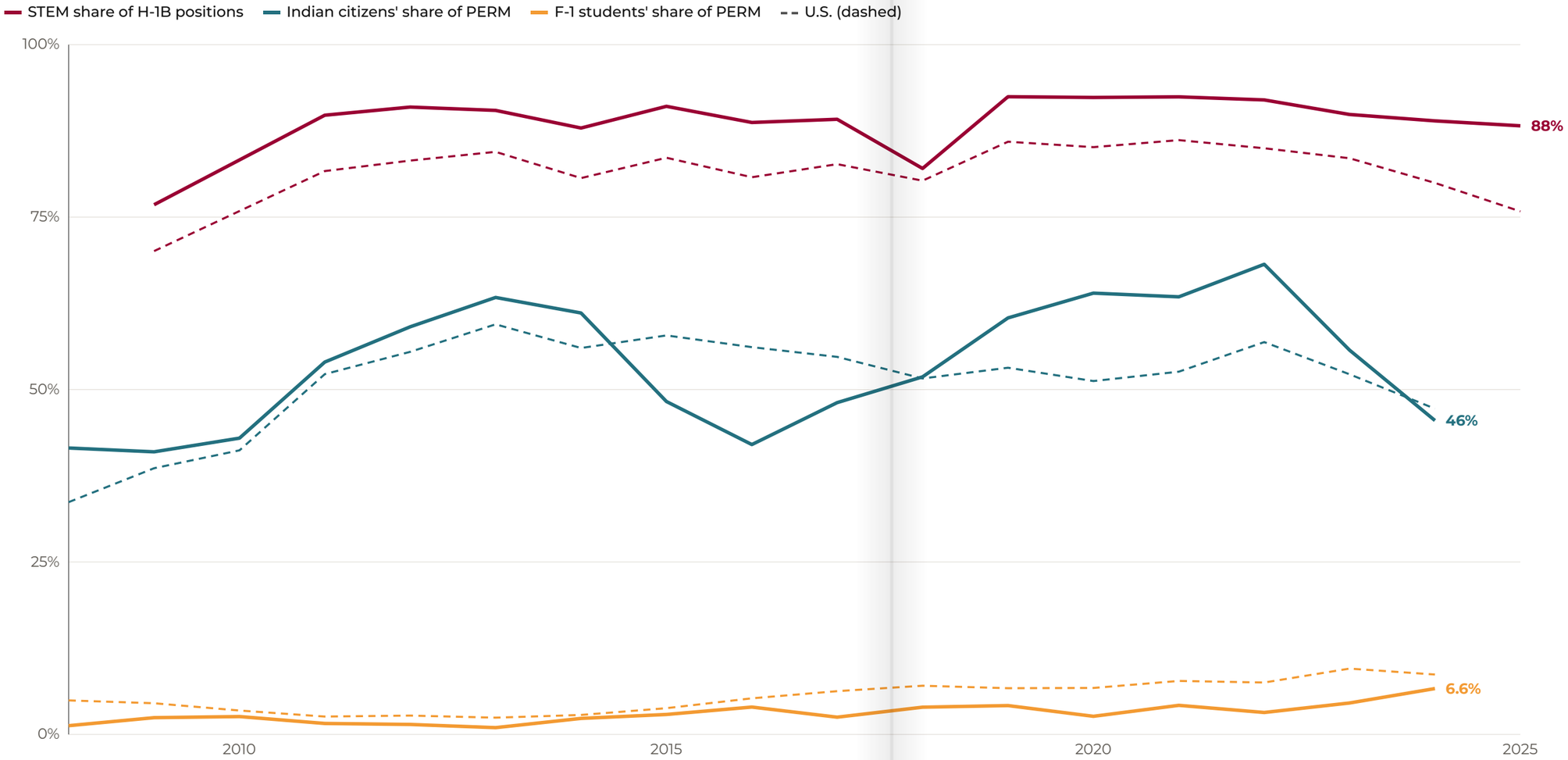
29.3K
Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025
U.S. **914K** · **7th** of 51 · −14% since 2015

3.77K
PERM green-card certifications, 2025
U.S. **138K** · **10th** of 51 · 2.27× since 2015

6.6%
PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024
U.S. **8.7%** · **39th** of 51 · +3.7 pp since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 19 Who Holds North Carolina's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

88% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 46% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

88%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **3rd** of 51 · −2.8 pp since 2015

46%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **17th** of 51 · −2.7 pp since 2015

$113K

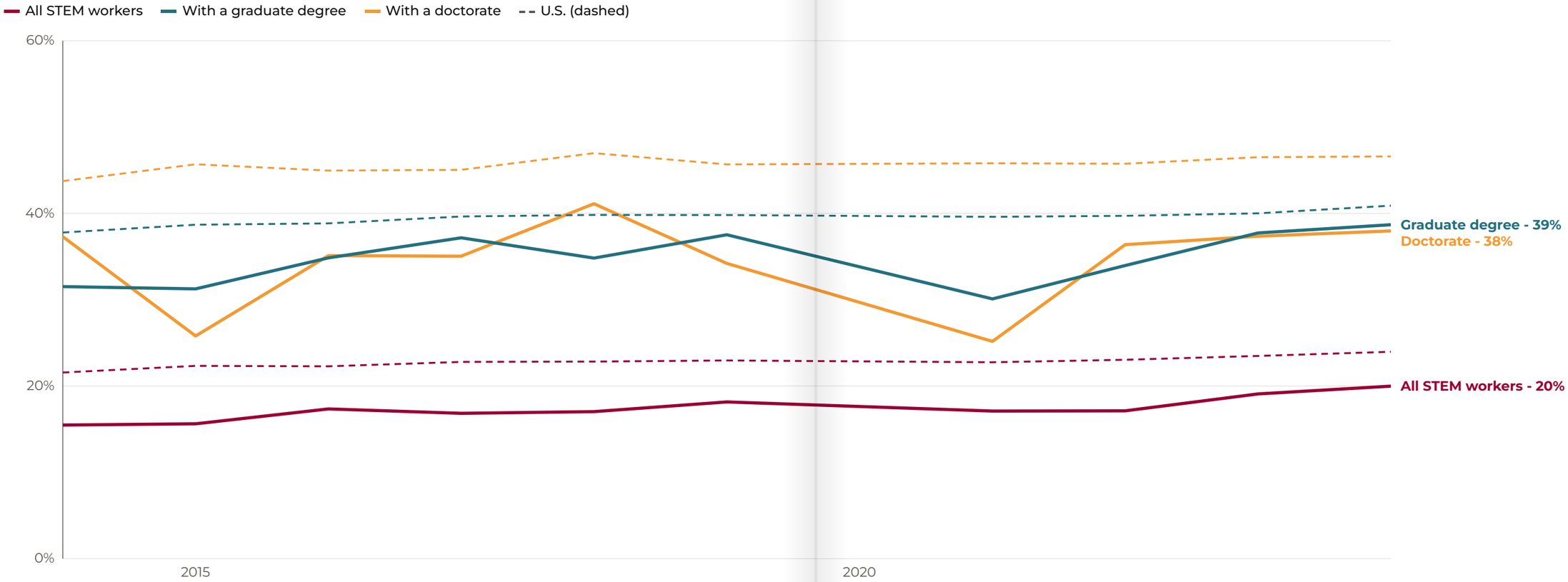
Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

U.S. **$119K** · **12th** of 51 · +59% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Figure 20 How Much of North Carolina's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 20% of the people working in STEM occupations in North Carolina were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 15th of 51).

The share rises with education: 39% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 11% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.

20%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **15th** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

39%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **12th** of 44 · +7.4 pp since 2015

11%

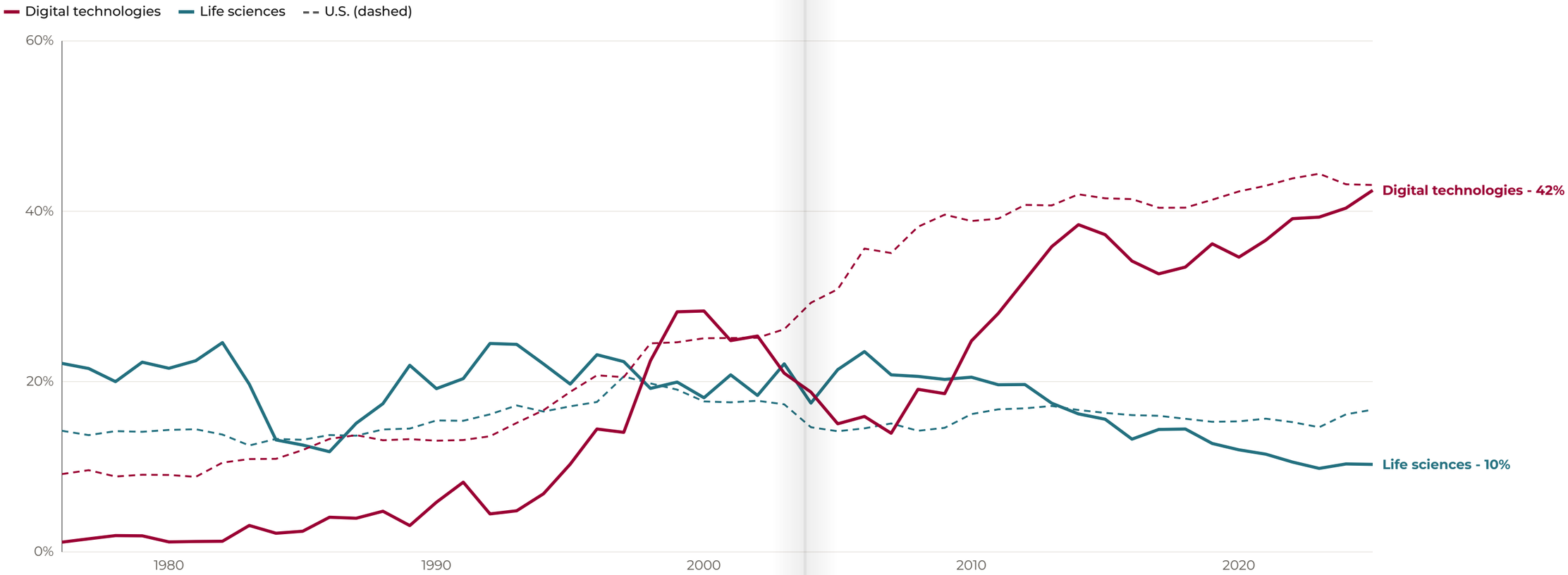
Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **11%** · **11th** of 51 · +1.8 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does North Carolina Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in North Carolina were granted 4.33K U.S. patents in 2025, 3.2% of all patents with a U.S. owner (8th of 51). 42% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 10% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

4.33K

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **8th** of 51 · +70% since 2015

42%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **11th** of 51 · +5.2 pp since 2015

10%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

U.S. **17%** · **42nd** of 51 · −5.3 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in size are Virginia, Georgia, Ohio, Pennsylvania. North Carolina ranks 3rd of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Ohio is the most dependent at 58%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are North Carolina and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?

Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

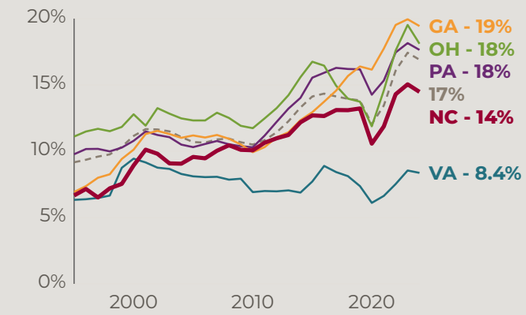
NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Table 3 How Does North Carolina Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	NC	VA	GA	OH	PA	U.S.
Students enrolled	**582K**	575K	594K	611K	637K	19.7M
Graduate share of students	**14%**	22%	18%	14%	23%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's	**26%**	24%	27%	24%	27%	24%
STEM share of master's	**22%**	19%	28%	27%	25%	23%
International STEM master's	**2.42K**	2.07K	3.78K	3.84K	5.51K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's	**2.1%**	1.8%	3.2%	3.3%	4.7%	100%
Int. share of STEM master's	**49%**	39%	44%	58%	54%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates	**39%**	41%	44%	45%	45%	43%
Int. share of grad students	**14%**	8.4%	19%	18%	18%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment	**2.1%**	2.7%	2.6%	3.3%	3.9%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate	**66%**	68%	57%	62%	68%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year	**$7.54K**	$15.7K	$7.14K	$11K	$17K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student	**$15.6K**	$11.3K	$10.8K	$7.76K	$7.14K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary	**$95.1K**	$106K	$95.3K	$93.3K	$109K	$106K
First-time students from in state	**79%**	75%	82%	76%	68%	–
Net migration per 100 residents	**+4**	+2	−6	+5	+8	–

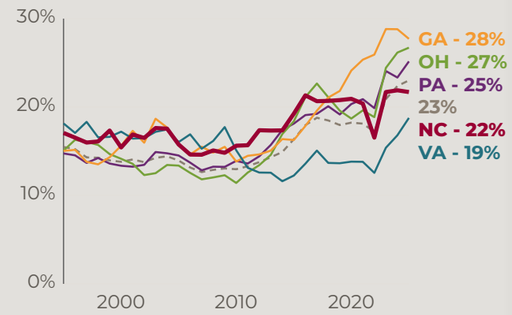
Latest year for each measure. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



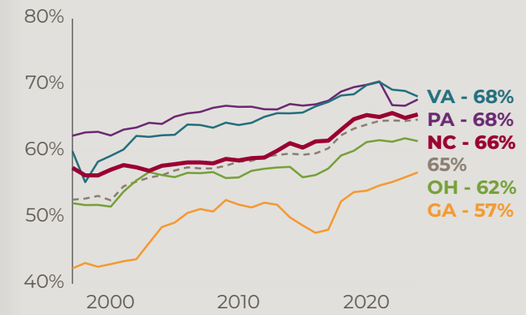
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



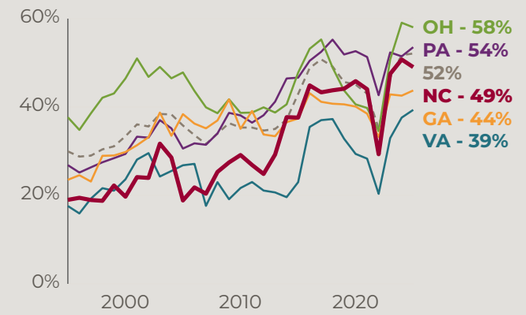
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM master's

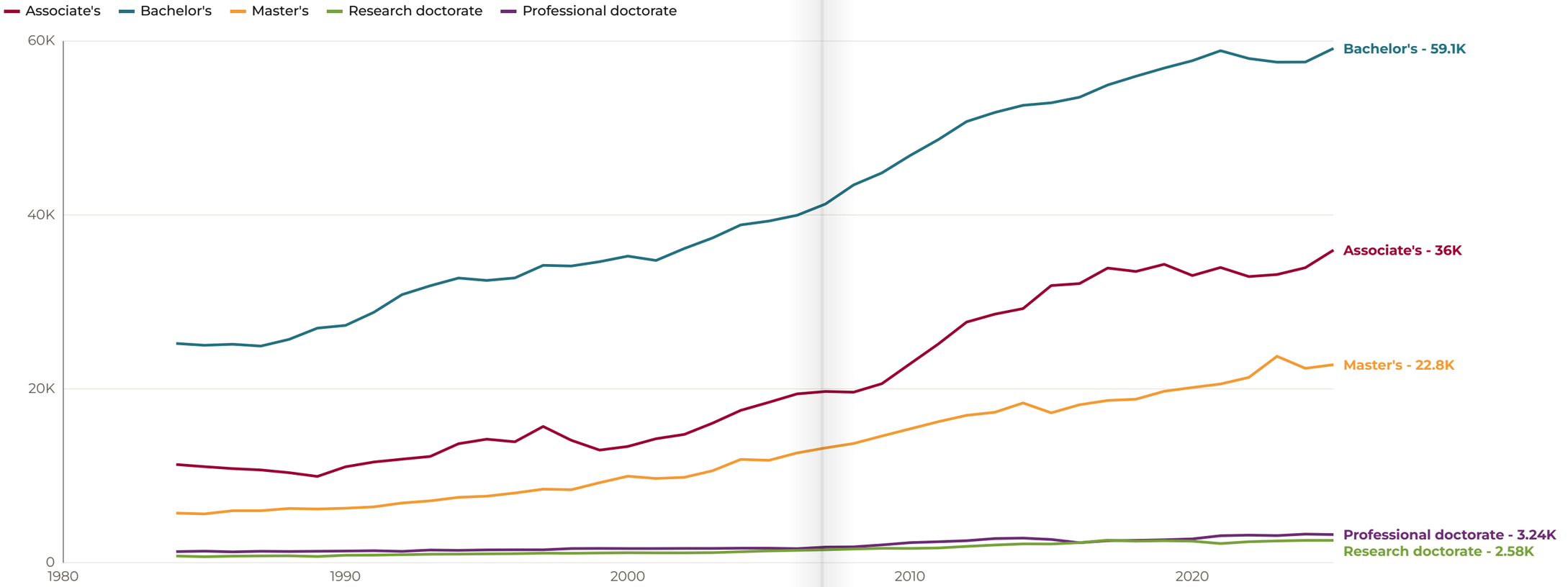


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does North Carolina Award?

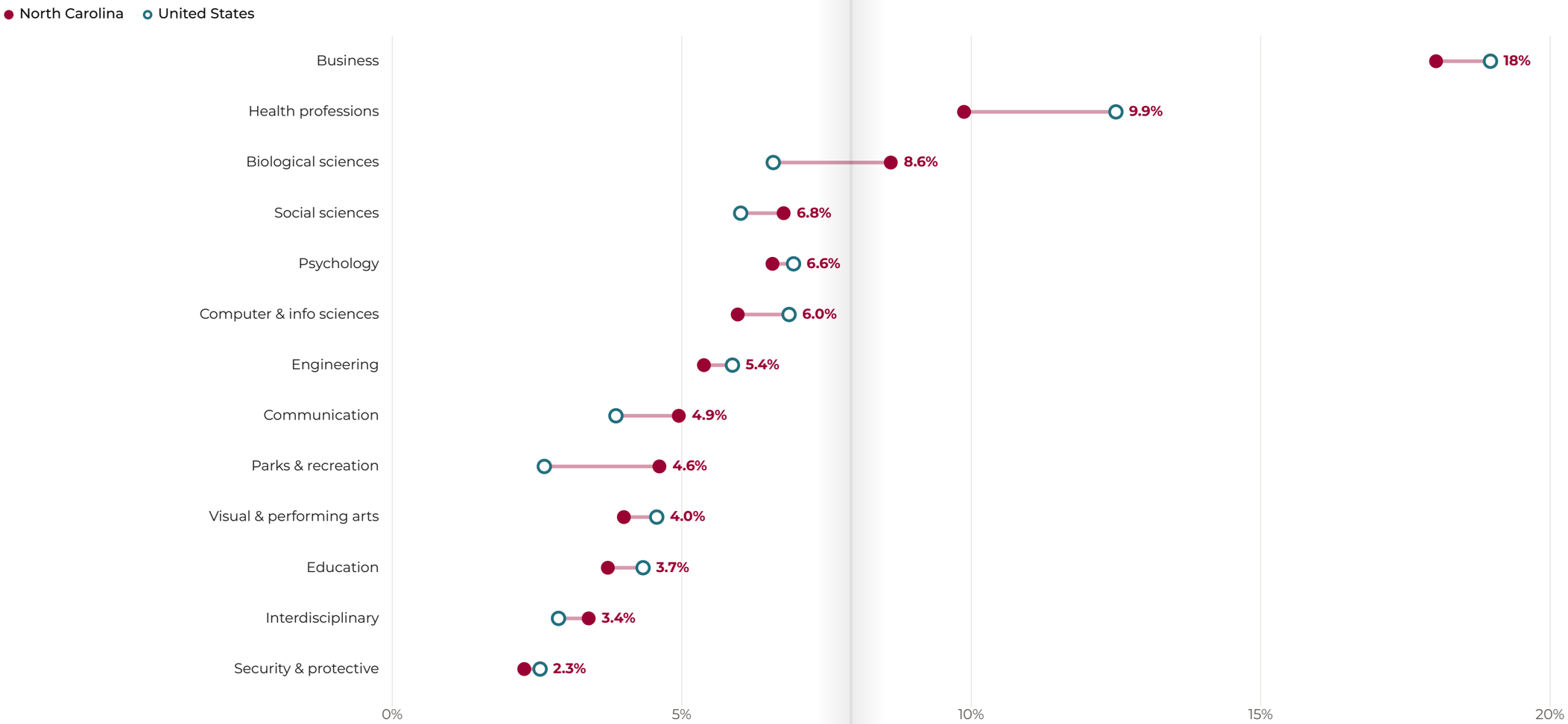


Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, North Carolina's institutions awarded 36K associate's degrees, 59.1K bachelor's degrees, 22.8K master's degrees, 2.58K research doctorate degrees, 3.24K professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's up 13%; bachelor's up 12%; master's up 32%; research doctorate up 19%; professional doctorate up 21%. The state awards 11.8 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

Figure 28 What Do North Carolina's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

North Carolina's largest bachelor's fields are business (18%; U.S. 19%), health professions (9.9%; U.S. 13%), biological sciences (8.6%; U.S. 6.6%).

Relative to the nation, North Carolina's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in parks & recreation (1.76× the U.S. share), engineering technology (1.55× the U.S. share), public administration (1.36× the U.S. share).

6.0%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **24th** of 51 · +3.4 pp since 2015

6.8%

Bachelor's in engineering, 2025

U.S. **6.8%** · **23rd** of 51 · +1.3 pp since 2015

18%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **33rd** of 51 · +1.2 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do North Carolina's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

North Carolina's largest master's fields are business (27%; U.S. 21%), health professions (16%; U.S. 15%), education (11%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 19% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 22% of them.

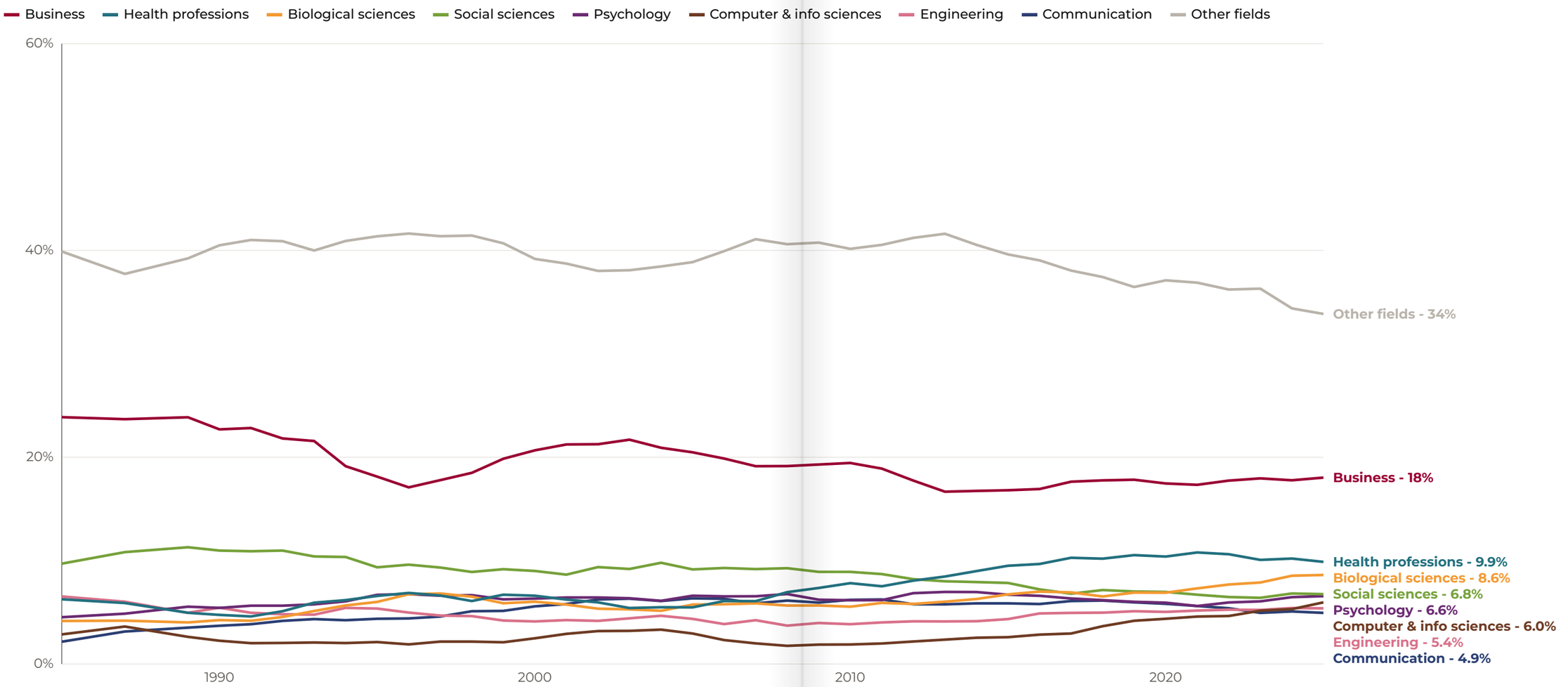
22%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **24th** of 51 · +2.4 pp since 2015

19%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **21st** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

64%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **25th** of 47 · +16.3 pp since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 30 How Has North Carolina's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, computer & info sciences has gained the most ground, 3.4 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while social sciences lost the most (1.1 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

Table 4 Where Is North Carolina Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Parks & recreation	**1.76**	4.6%	2.6%	2.73K
Engineering technology	**1.55**	1.4%	0.9%	819
Public administration	**1.36**	2.0%	1.5%	1.18K
Biological sciences	**1.31**	8.6%	6.6%	5.09K
Physical sciences	**1.29**	1.7%	1.3%	981
Natural resources	**1.28**	1.4%	1.1%	847
Communication	**1.28**	4.9%	3.9%	2.93K
Interdisciplinary	**1.18**	3.4%	2.9%	2.01K
Math & statistics	**1.18**	1.4%	1.2%	817
Agriculture	**1.13**	1.2%	1.0%	685

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

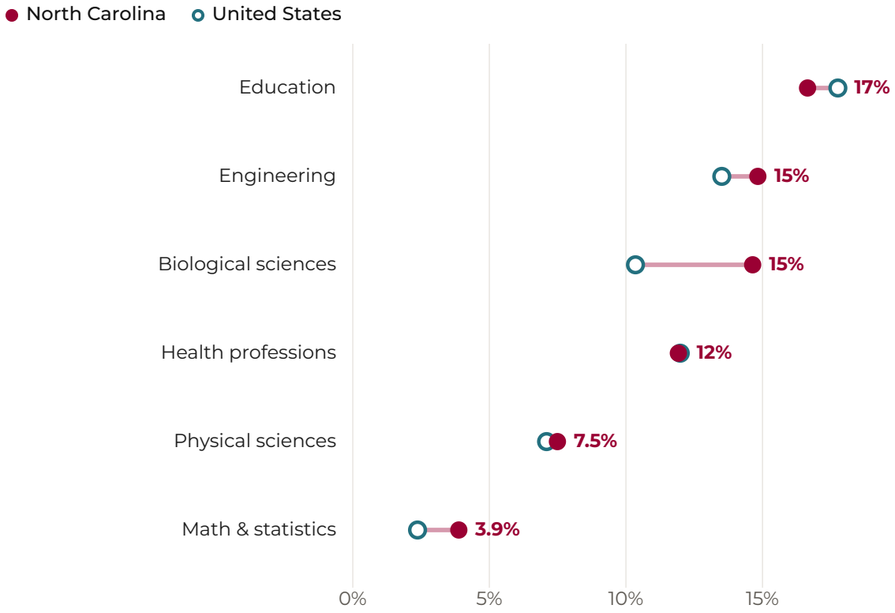
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The location quotient divides a field's share of North Carolina's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the ten fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest location quotients**: parks & recreation 1.76 (4.6% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 2.6%); engineering technology 1.55 (1.4% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 0.9%); public administration 1.36 (2.0% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 1.5%).
- **STEM share of bachelor's degrees**: 26% in 2025 (U.S. 24%; 13th of 51 states), up 0.6 points from 26% in 2024, and up 6.4 points since 2015 (20%).
- **Computer and information sciences**: 6.0% in 2025 (U.S. 6.9%; 24th of 51 states), up 0.7 points from 5.3% in 2024, and up 3.4 points since 2015 (2.6%).
- **Engineering**: 6.8% in 2025 (U.S. 6.8%; 23rd of 51 states), unchanged from 6.8% in 2024, and up 1.3 points since 2015 (5.5%).

Figure 31 What Do North Carolina's Doctoral Graduates Study?



Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in North Carolina in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

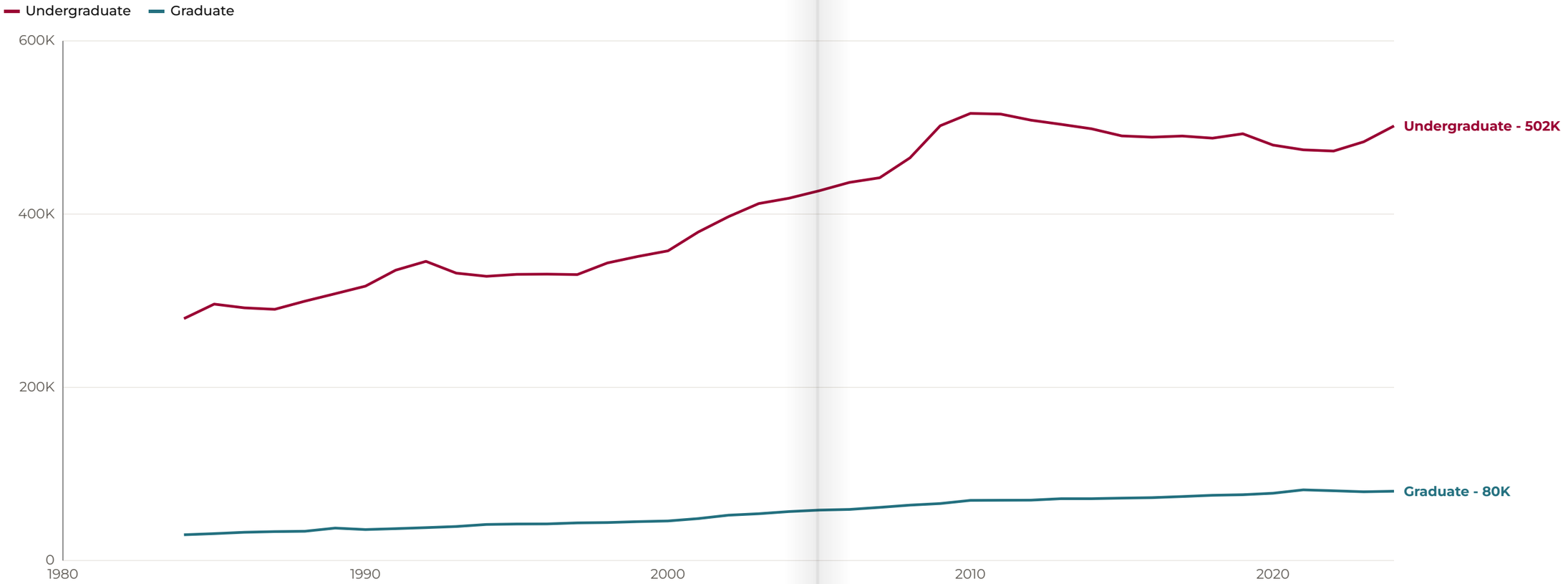
THE NUMBERS

- **Largest doctoral fields**: education 17% (U.S. 18%); engineering 15% (U.S. 14%); biological sciences 15% (U.S. 10%).
- **STEM share of research doctorates**: 46% in 2025 (U.S. 39%; 14th of 51 states), down 1.9 points from 48% in 2024, and down 0.1 points since 2015 (46%).
- **International share of research doctorates**: 25% in 2025 (U.S. 25%; 30th of 51 states), down 3.1 points from 28% in 2024, and up 0.8 points since 2015 (24%).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 39% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 30th of 51 states), down 4.7 points from 44% in 2024, and up 1.0 point since 2015 (38%).

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, North Carolina enrolled 502K undergraduates and 80K graduate students, 582K in all (10th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is up 2% since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 11% since 2015. Graduate students are 14% of all students (U.S. 17%).

582K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **10th** of 51 · +3.4% since 2015

14%

Graduate share of students, 2024

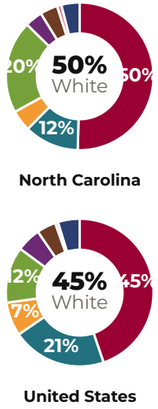
U.S. **17%** · **34th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

39%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **29th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in North Carolina?



	North Carolina	United States
White	**50%**	45%
Hispanic	**12%**	21%
Asian / Pacific Islander	**4.6%**	7.4%
Black	**20%**	12%
International	**3.8%**	5.3%
Two or more	**3.8%**	4.2%
American Indian	**0.9%**	0.6%
Unknown	**4.0%**	4.8%

Share of fall 2024 enrollment by race and ethnicity. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

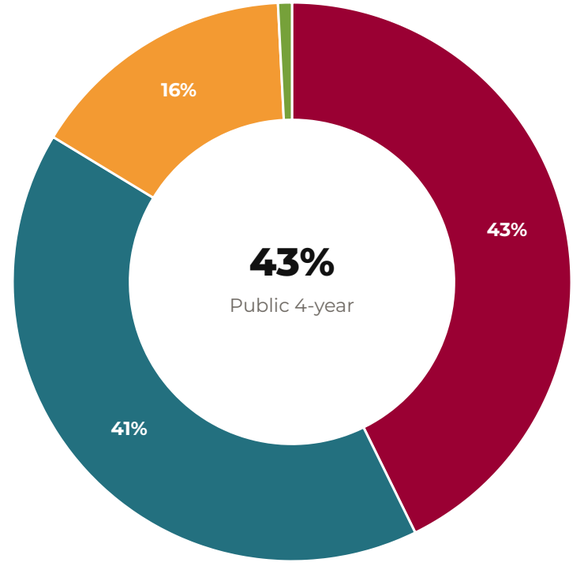
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The rings divide fall 2024 headcount enrollment at North Carolina's degree-granting institutions by race and ethnicity, with the nation for comparison. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race; "Unknown" is students whose race was not reported.

THE NUMBERS

- **White**: 50% in fall 2024 (U.S. 45%), down 1.5 points from 52% in fall 2023, and down 6.3 points since fall 2015 (57%).
- **Black**: 20% in fall 2024 (U.S. 12%), unchanged from 20% in fall 2023, and down 2.2 points since fall 2015 (23%).
- **Hispanic**: 12% in fall 2024 (U.S. 21%), up 0.7 points from 11% in fall 2023, and up 5.4 points since fall 2015 (6.6%).
- **Asian / Pacific Islander**: 4.6% in fall 2024 (U.S. 7.4%), up 0.1 points from 4.5% in fall 2023, and up 1.4 points since fall 2015 (3.2%).
- **Unknown**: 4.0% in fall 2024 (U.S. 4.8%), up 0.6 points from 3.4% in fall 2023, and up 0.5 points since fall 2015 (3.5%).

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



	Share
Public 4-year	**43%**
Public 2-year	**41%**
Private nonprofit	**16%**
For-profit	**0.8%**

Share of fall 2024 enrollment by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

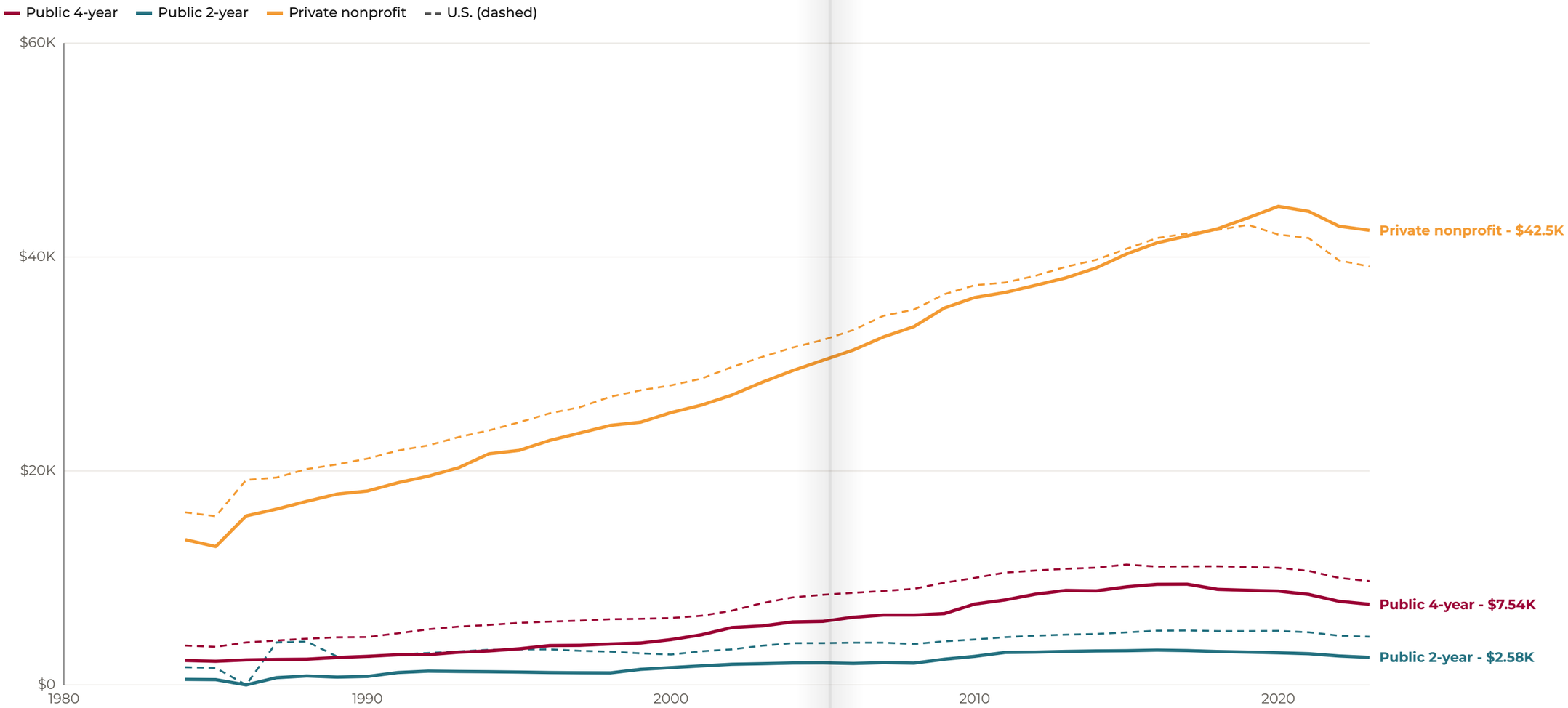
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The ring divides fall 2024 headcount enrollment in North Carolina among public four-year, public two-year, private nonprofit and for-profit institutions.

THE NUMBERS

- **Public 4-year share of enrollment**: 43% in fall 2024, down 0.4 points from 43% in fall 2023, and up 2.7 points since fall 2015 (40%).
- **Public 2-year share of enrollment**: 41% in fall 2024, up 1.4 points from 40% in fall 2023, and up 1.3 points since fall 2015 (40%).
- **Private nonprofit share of enrollment**: 16% in fall 2024, down 0.4 points from 16% in fall 2023, and down 1.8 points since fall 2015 (17%).
- **For-profit share of enrollment**: 0.8% in fall 2024, down 0.5 points from 1.3% in fall 2023, and down 2.2 points since fall 2015 (3.0%).

Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at North Carolina's public four-year institutions are $7.54K (2023, 2024 dollars), 22% below the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 45th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $15.6K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (9th of 51), and tuition makes up 28% of their core revenue (U.S. 43%).

$7.54K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **45th** of 51 · −18% since 2015

$15.6K

Appropriations per student, 2024

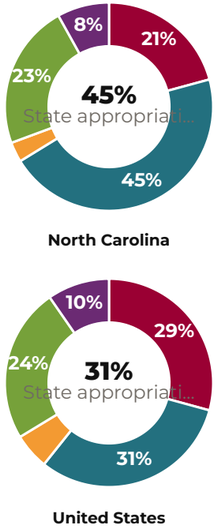
U.S. **$11.4K** · **9th** of 51 · +12% since 2015

28%

Tuition share of public revenue, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **46th** of 51 · −4.3 pp since 2015

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



	North Carolina	United States
Net tuition	**21%**	29%
State appropriations	**45%**	31%
Local appropriations	**3.1%**	5.6%
Federal grants & appropriations	**23%**	24%
Private gifts & grants	**8.1%**	9.6%

Core revenue per FTE student, public institutions. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The rings divide the core revenue of North Carolina's public institutions per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student by source, with the nation for comparison. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

THE NUMBERS

- **Net tuition per FTE student**: $6.7K in FY2024 (U.S. $8.96K), down 1.1% from $6.77K in FY2023, and down 5.6% since FY2015 ($7.09K).
- **State appropriations per FTE student**: $14.6K in FY2024 (U.S. $9.64K), up 3.7% from $14.1K in FY2023, and up 13% since FY2015 ($13K).
- **Local appropriations per FTE student**: $1K in FY2024 (U.S. $1.71K), up 2.7% from $977 in FY2023, and up 10% since FY2015 ($909).
- **Federal grants & appropriations per FTE student**: $7.27K in FY2024 (U.S. $7.36K), down 9.1% from $7.99K in FY2023, and down 4.3% since FY2015 ($7.6K).

Table 5 Money and Results

Measure	Year	North Carolina	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$7.54K**	$9.71K	45th of 51	−18%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$15.6K**	$11.4K	9th of 51	+12%
Tuition share of public revenue	2024	**28%**	43%	46th of 51	−4.3 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**66%**	65%	22nd of 51	+5.0 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$95.1K**	$106K	28th of 51	−6.3%

Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in North Carolina: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

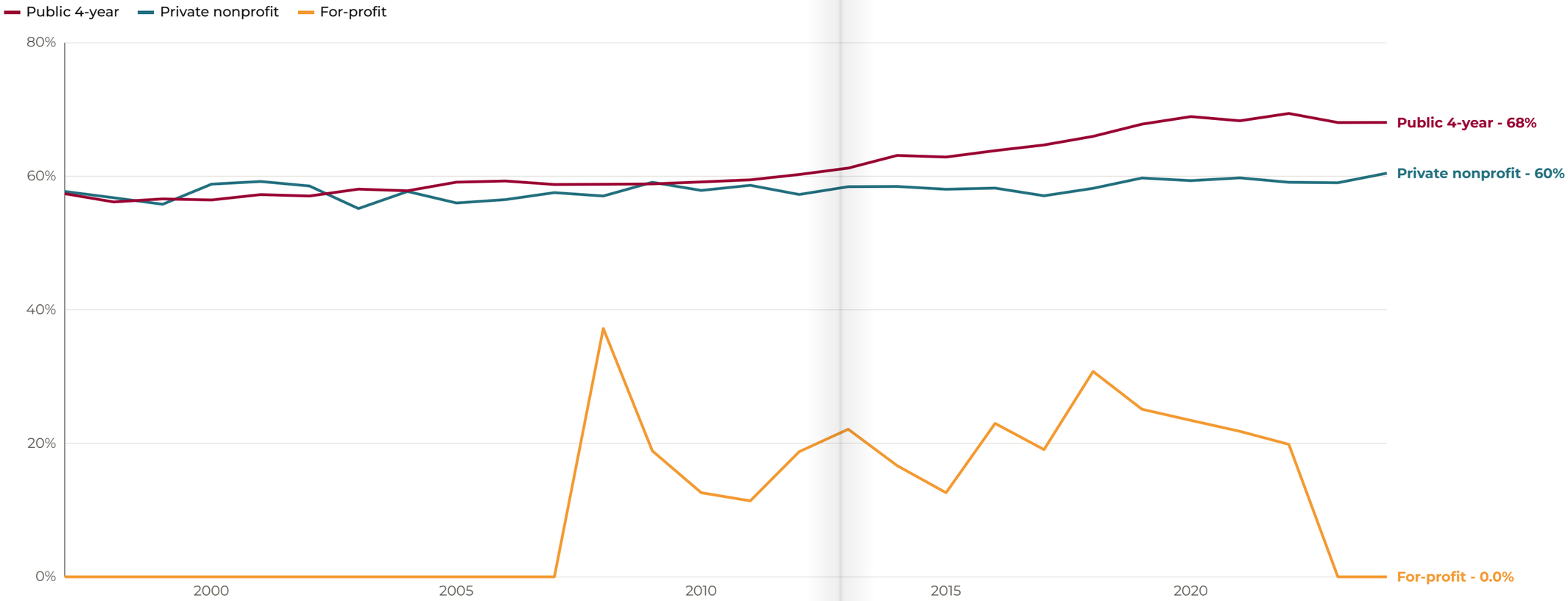
THE NUMBERS

- **In-state tuition, public 4-year**: $7.54K in 2023 (U.S. $9.71K; 45th of 51 states), down 3.5% from $7.81K in 2022, and down 18% since 2015 ($9.17K).
- **Appropriations per student**: $15.6K in 2024 (U.S. $11.4K; 9th of 51 states), up 3.6% from $15.1K in 2023, and up 12% since 2015 ($13.9K).
- **Tuition share of public revenue**: 28% in 2024 (U.S. 43%; 46th of 51 states), down 1.1 points from 29% in 2023, and down 4.3 points since 2015 (32%).
- **Six-year graduation rate**: 66% in 2024 (U.S. 65%; 22nd of 51 states), up 0.5 points from 65% in 2023, and up 5.0 points since 2015 (61%).

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

66% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in North Carolina graduated within six years (2024), 0.8 points above the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 22nd of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 68%, private nonprofit 60%, for-profit 0.0%. At two-year institutions, 41% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

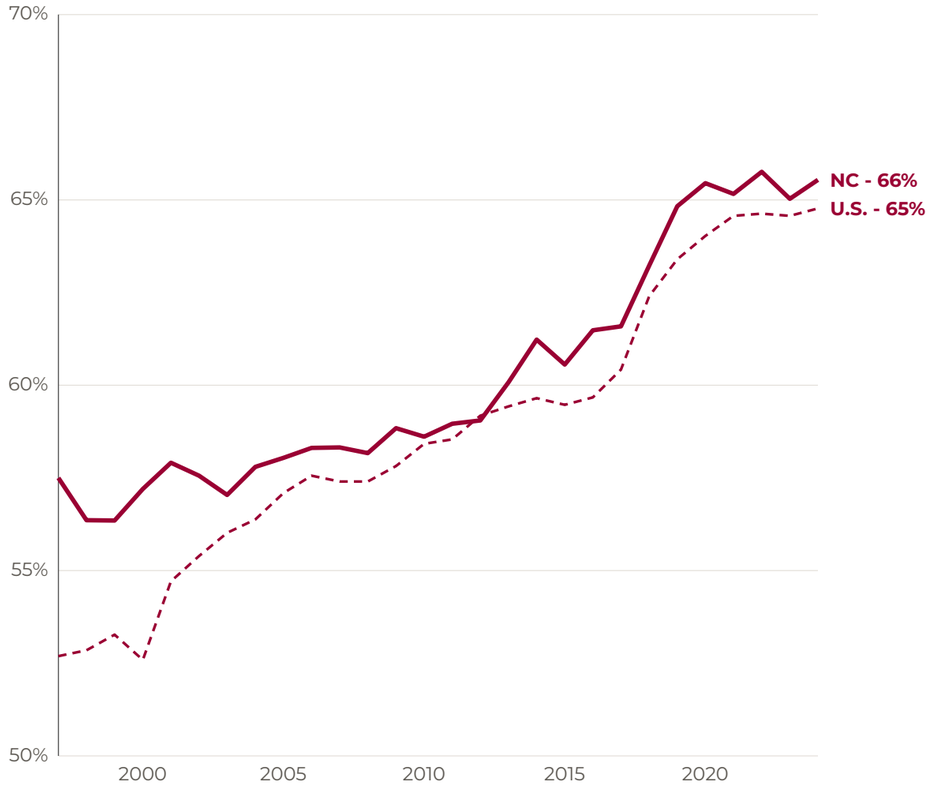
66%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **22nd** of 51 · +5.0 pp since 2015

41%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **26th** of 50 · +22.2 pp since 2015

11.8
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **37th** of 51 · +1.2 since 2015

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

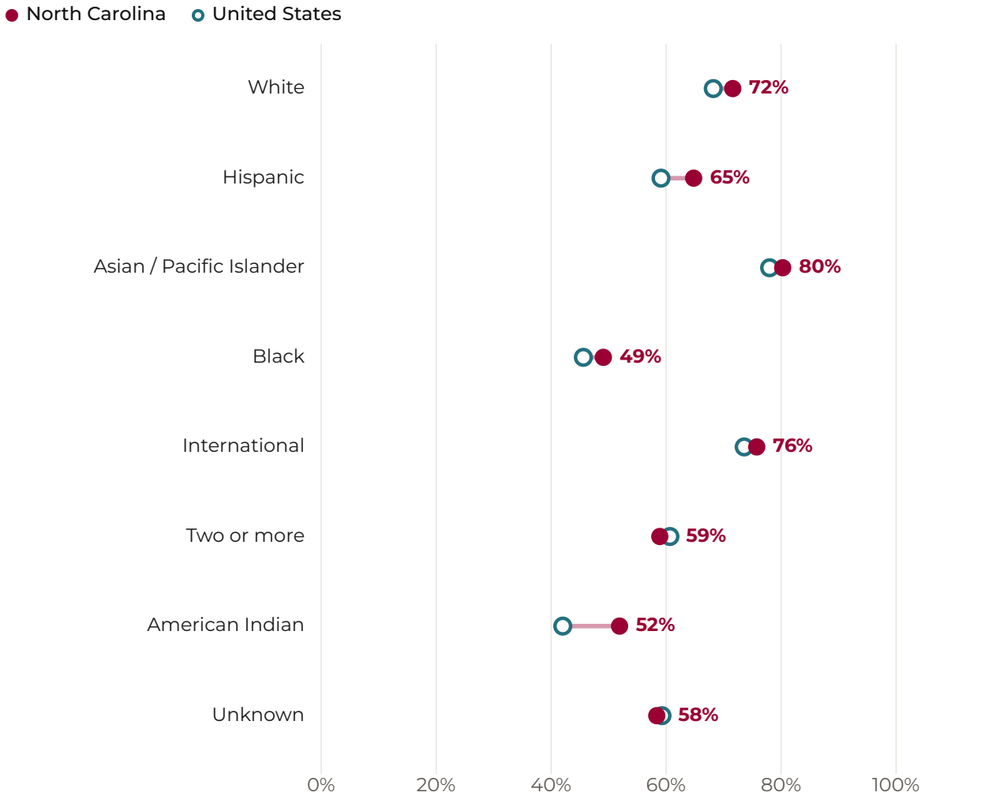
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at North Carolina's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

THE NUMBERS

- **Six-year graduation rate**: 66% in 2024 (U.S. 65%), up 0.5 points from 65% in 2023, and up 5.0 points since 2015 (61%).
- **Public 4-year institutions**: 68% in 2024, unchanged from 68% in 2023, and up 5.2 points since 2015 (63%).
- **Private nonprofit institutions**: 60% in 2024, up 1.4 points from 59% in 2023, and up 2.4 points since 2015 (58%).
- **For-profit institutions**: 0.0% in 2024, unchanged from 0.0% in 2023, and down 12.6 points since 2015 (13%).
- **Two-year institutions, completion within 150% of normal time**: 41% in 2024 (U.S. 41%), up 3.2 points from 38% in 2023, and up 22.2 points since 2015 (19%).
- **State rank on the six-year rate**: 66% in 2024 (U.S. 65%; 22nd of 51 states), up 0.5 points from 65% in 2023, and up 5.0 points since 2015 (61%).

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at North Carolina's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

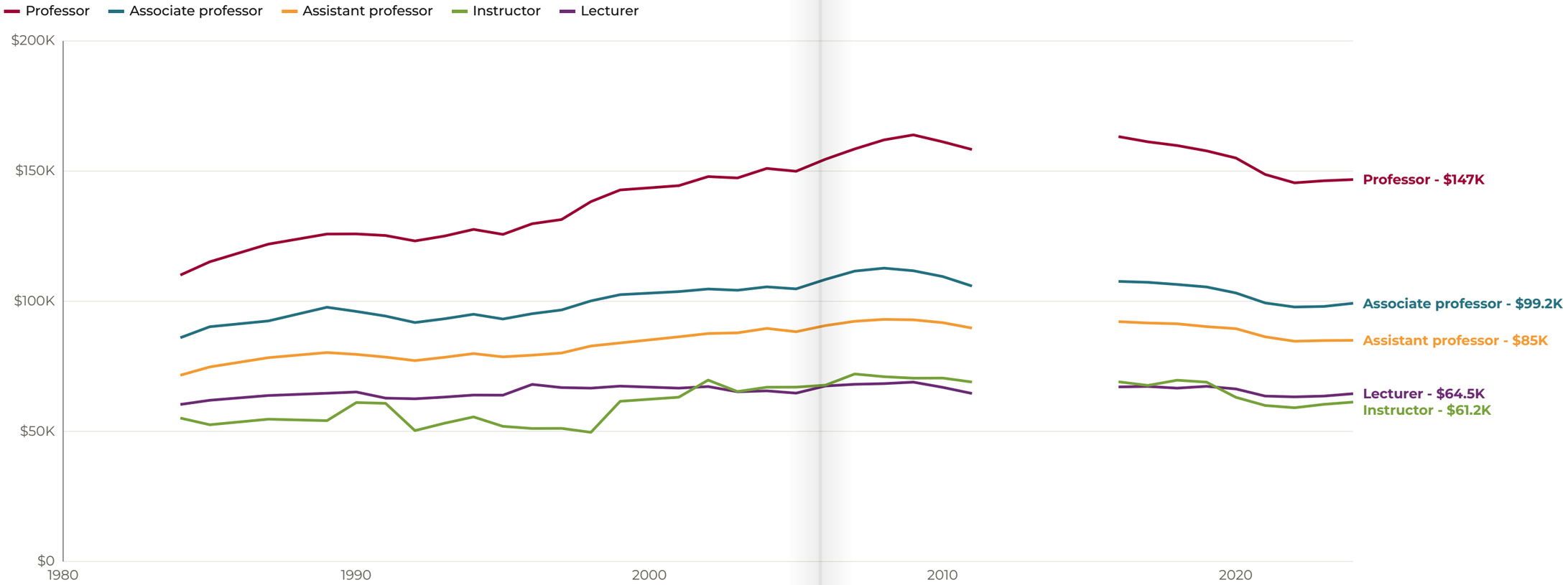
THE NUMBERS

- **White**: 72% in 2024 (U.S. 68%).
- **Hispanic**: 65% in 2024 (U.S. 59%).
- **Asian / Pacific Islander**: 80% in 2024 (U.S. 78%).
- **Black**: 49% in 2024 (U.S. 46%).
- **International**: 76% in 2024 (U.S. 74%).
- **Two or more**: 59% in 2024 (U.S. 61%).
- **American Indian**: 52% in 2024 (U.S. 42%).

SECTION 15

Faculty

Figure 40 What Do North Carolina's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at North Carolina's institutions earned an average of $95.1K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 10% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 28th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $147K, associate professors $99.2K, assistant professors $85K, instructors $61.2K, lecturers $64.5K.

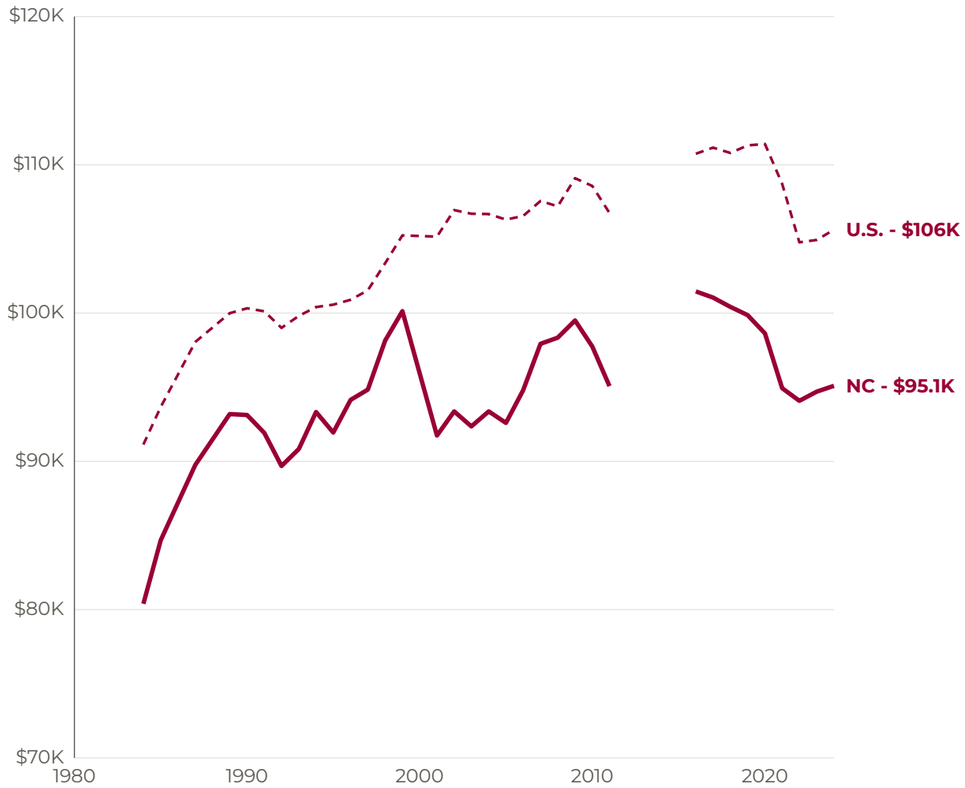
North Carolina's institutions had 29.4K full-time instructional staff in 2024, up 10% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 6% since 2016.

$95.1K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **28th** of 51 · −6.3% since 2016

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

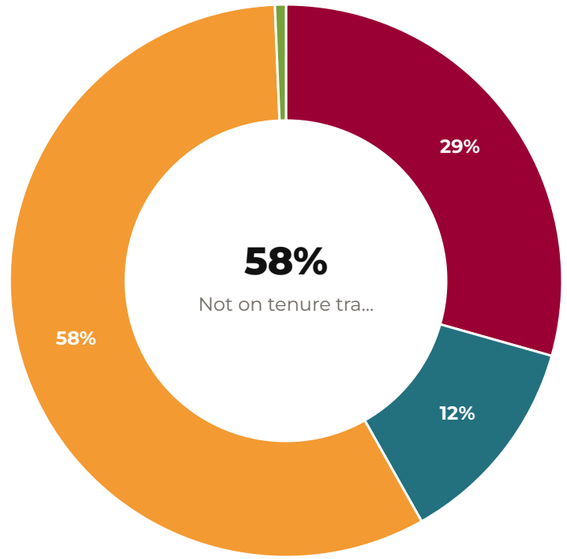
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at North Carolina's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

THE NUMBERS

- **Average salary**: $95.1K in 2024 (U.S. $106K), up 0.4% from $94.7K in 2023, and down 6.3% since 2016 ($101K).
- **State rank on average salary**: $95.1K in 2024 (U.S. $106K; 28th of 51 states), up 0.4% from $94.7K in 2023, and down 6.3% since 2016 ($101K).
- **Full-time instructional staff**: 29.4K in 2024, up 2.7% from 28.6K in 2023, and up 10% since 2015 (26.7K).
- **Professors, average salary**: $147K in 2024, up 0.3% from $146K in 2023, and down 10% since 2016 ($163K).
- **Associate professors, average salary**: $99.2K in 2024, up 1.2% from $98K in 2023, and down 7.8% since 2016 ($108K).
- **Assistant professors, average salary**: $85K in 2024, up 0.1% from $84.9K in 2023, and down 7.8% since 2016 ($92.2K).

Figure 42 Tenure Status



	Share
Tenured	29%
On tenure track	12%
Not on tenure track	58%
No faculty status	0.6%

Full-time instructional staff, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The ring divides North Carolina's full-time instructional staff in 2024 by tenure status: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

THE NUMBERS

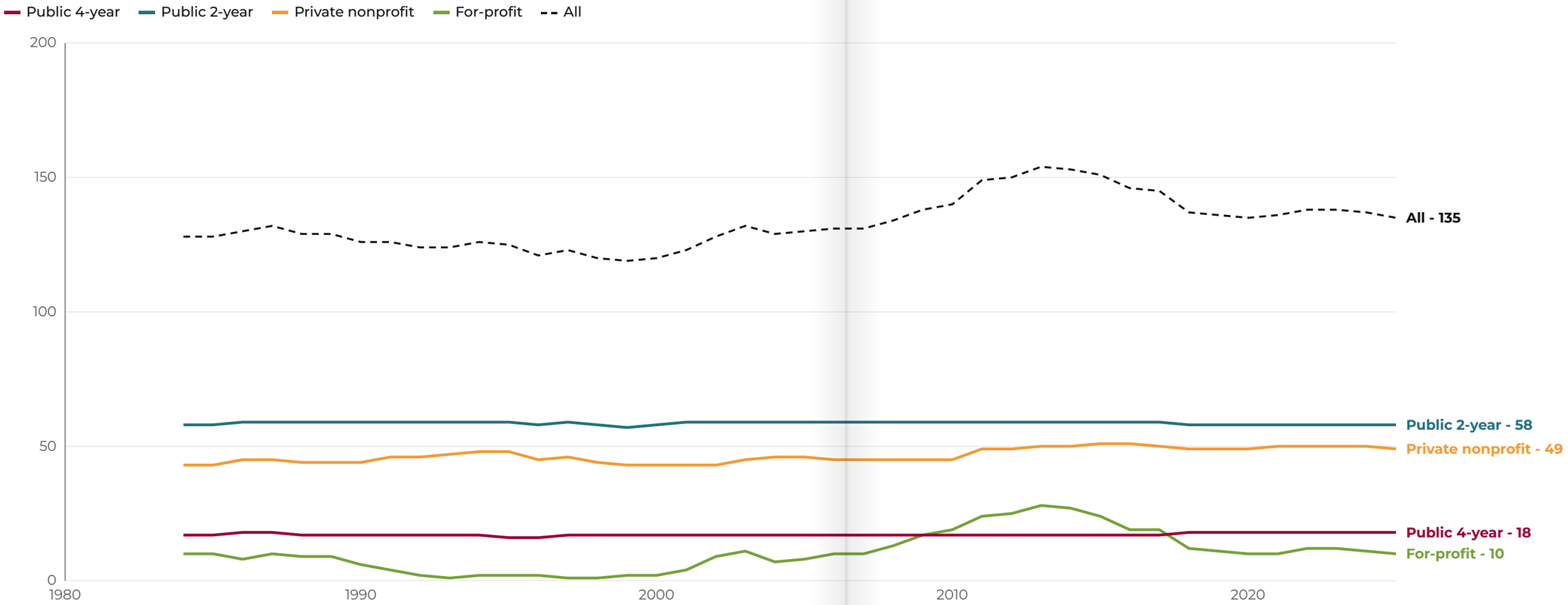
- **Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff**: 29% in 2024, down 1.1 points from 31% in 2023, and down 3.5 points since 2015 (33%).
- **On tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff**: 12% in 2024, up 0.2 points from 12% in 2023, and down 0.8 points since 2015 (13%).
- **Not on tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff**: 58% in 2024, up 0.9 points from 57% in 2023, and up 4.4 points since 2015 (53%).
- **No faculty status, share of full-time instructional staff**: 0.6% in 2024, unchanged from 0.6% in 2023, and down 0.1 points since 2015 (0.7%).

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 16

Institutions

Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does North Carolina Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

North Carolina has 134 degree-granting institutions: 18 public 4-year, 58 public 2-year, 49 private nonprofit, 10 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 11% since 2015. 84% of students attend public institutions and 0.8% attend for-profit ones.

84%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **18th** of 51 · +4.0 pp since 2015

0.8%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **36th** of 51 · −2.2 pp since 2015

27%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **20th** of 51 · +12.5 pp since 2015

Table 6 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	Intl STEM master's	Int. share	Intl STEM doctorates	Int. share
North Carolina State University at Raleigh Raleigh · Public 4-year	**811**	46%	187	47%
Duke University Durham · Private nonprofit	**688**	61%	123	41%
University of North Carolina at Charlotte Charlotte · Public 4-year	**640**	69%	40	71%
University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill Chapel Hill · Public 4-year	**82**	33%	58	21%
North Carolina A & T State University Greensboro · Public 4-year	**75**	38%	33	58%
University of North Carolina at Greensboro Greensboro · Public 4-year	**64**	48%	8	36%
Wake Forest University Winston-Salem · Private nonprofit	**11**	21%	14	28%
University of North Carolina Wilmington Wilmington · Public 4-year	**18**	14%	1	20%
East Carolina University Greenville · Public 4-year	**9**	6.1%	2	8.0%
North Carolina Central University Durham · Public 4-year	**10**	21%	–	–%

Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Institutions in North Carolina ranked by the STEM master's and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

THE NUMBERS

- **Largest**: North Carolina State University at Raleigh (811 international STEM master's, 187 doctorates); Duke University (688 international STEM master's, 123 doctorates); University of North Carolina at Charlotte (640 international STEM master's, 40 doctorates).
- **International STEM master's degrees, all institutions**: 2.42K in 2025 (U.S. 117K; 17th of 51 states), down 2.5% from 2.48K in 2024, and up 94% since 2015 (1.25K).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 39% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 30th of 51 states), down 4.7 points from 44% in 2024, and up 1.0 point since 2015 (38%).

Table 7 What Are North Carolina's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
North Carolina State University at Raleigh	**38.5K**	30%	3.24K	85%	42%
University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill	**32.4K**	12%	2.02K	91%	15%
University of North Carolina at Charlotte	**31.1K**	27%	2.36K	69%	80%
East Carolina University	**26.9K**	2.1%	1.07K	63%	89%
Wake Technical Community College	**24.6K**	–	–	–	–
Appalachian State University	**21.6K**	1.5%	897	75%	90%
Central Piedmont Community College	**20.4K**	–	–	–	–
University of North Carolina Wilmington	**18.8K**	2.6%	650	71%	64%
University of North Carolina at Greensboro	**18K**	9.7%	539	56%	89%
Duke University	**17.5K**	35%	1K	97%	5.7%
North Carolina A & T State University	**14.3K**	21%	724	57%	50%
Cape Fear Community College	**14.1K**	–	–	–	–
Fayetteville Technical Community College	**11.8K**	–	–	–	–
Western Carolina University	**11.7K**	2.4%	400	60%	82%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

North Carolina's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

THE NUMBERS

- **Largest**: North Carolina State University at Raleigh (38.5K students); University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill (32.4K students); University of North Carolina at Charlotte (31.1K students).
- **Degree-granting institutions**: 134.
- **Share of students at public institutions**: 84% in 2024 (U.S. 73%; 18th of 51 states), up 1.0 point from 83% in 2023, and up 4.0 points since 2015 (80%).
- **Share at for-profit institutions**: 0.8% in 2024 (U.S. 5.5%; 36th of 51 states), down 0.5 points from 1.3% in 2023, and down 2.2 points since 2015 (3.0%).

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

All dollar values are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts.

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

Source

National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions components, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. Department of Homeland Security, SEVIS by the Numbers data mapping tool, 2014–2026. Generated November 2026.

NORTH CAROLINA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

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North Carolina – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	281	**276**[2024]	−5.5 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#20	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	33%	**31%**[2024]	−1.1 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#14	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	244	**239**[2024]	−4.9 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#19	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	44%	**41%**[2024]	−3.1 pp ▼	39%	0.0 pp	#19	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	261	**255**[2024]	−5.7 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#35	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	30%	**27%**[2024]	−3.4 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#32	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	226	**213**[2024]	−12.5 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#32	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**150**[2015]	–	153	–	#34	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$11.2K	**$12.4K**[2021]	+11% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#45	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	86%	**86%**[2022]	0.0 pp	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#25	[3]
Public high school graduates	97.4K	**109K**[2024]	+12% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#9	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$62.5K	**$58.9K**[2022]	−5.9% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#41	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	15.5	**15.4**[2022]	−0.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#18	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	1.54M	**1.56M**[2024]	+0.7% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#9	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	57%	**63%**[2023]	+5.3 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#7	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	6.3%	**8.0%**[2022]	+1.7 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#26	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	4.6%	**9.0%**[2023]	+4.4 pp ▲	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#13	[3]
High schools offering calculus	56%[2016]	**61%**[2024]	+4.4 pp ▲	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#16	[14]
High schools offering physics	50%[2016]	**52%**[2024]	+2.6 pp ▲	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#38	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	79%[2016]	**86%**[2024]	+7.4 pp ▲	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#18	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	92%[2016]	**96%**[2024]	+4.4 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#6	[14]
High schools offering computer science	48%[2021]	**76%**[2024]	+28.0 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#10	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	67%[2016]	**68%**[2024]	+0.9 pp ▲	56%	0.0 pp	#19	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	31%[2021]	**31%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#18	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	64%[2016]	**84%[2024]**	+20.8 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#13	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	15.2[2016]	**15.7[2024]**	+0.5 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#23	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.3[2016]	**1.9[2024]**	−0.4 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#39	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.4[2016]	**1.6[2024]**	−0.8 ▼	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#50	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	20.2[2016]	**17.5[2024]**	−2.6 ▼	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#31	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	11.2[2016]	**12.5[2024]**	+1.3 ▲	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#7	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	43%	**37%[2025]**	−5.9 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#18	[15]
Fall enrollment	562K	**582K[2024]**	+3.4% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#10	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	80%	**84%[2024]**	+4.0 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#18	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	3.0%	**0.8%[2024]**	−2.2 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#36	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	36%	**39%[2024]**	+2.7 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#29	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	13%	**14%[2024]**	+0.9 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#34	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	14%	**27%[2024]**	+12.5 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#20	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	1.7K	**1.97K[2025]**	+15% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#8	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	1.27K	**1.46K[2025]**	+14% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#9	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	3.1%	**3.3%[2025]**	+0.2 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#8	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	295	**352[2025]**	+19% ▲	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#12	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	147	**184[2025]**	+25% ▲	5.07K	+33% ▲	#8	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	3.3	**4.1[2025]**	+0.8 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#37	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	20%	**26%[2025]**	+6.4 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#13	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.6%	**6.0%[2025]**	+3.4 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	5.5%	**6.8%[2025]**	+1.3 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#23	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.3%	**1.4%[2025]**	+0.1 pp ▲	1.2%	0.0 pp	#9	[4]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	6.7%	**8.6%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	2.0%	**1.7%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#8	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	9.5%	**9.9%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#36	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	17%	**18%**[2025]	+1.2 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#33	[4]
STEM share of master's	19%	**22%**[2025]	+2.4 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	5.0%	**7.2%**[2025]	+2.3 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	7.0%	**7.9%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#11	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	1.4%	**1.2%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	2.2%	**2.4%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#26	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	1.3%	**1.1%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#19	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	15%	**16%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#18	[4]
Share of master's in business	26%	**27%**[2025]	+0.6 pp ▲	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#5	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	46%	**46%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#14	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	3.1%	**3.6%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	14%	**15%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#18	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	3.8%	**3.9%**[2025]	0.0 pp	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#2	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	16%	**15%**[2025]	−1.4 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#10	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	6.8%	**7.5%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#28	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	11%	**12%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#21	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	1.3%	**2.4%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#37	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	10.6	**11.8**[2025]	+1.2 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#37	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.6%[2016]	**1.7%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#39	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	1.25K	**2.42K**[2025]	+94% ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#17	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	2.3%	**2.1%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#17	[4]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	2.1%	**2.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#32	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	13%	**14%**[2024]	+1.8 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#24	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.1%	**3.3%**[2025]	+1.2 pp ▲	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#24	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	3.2%	**4.3%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#33	[4]
International share of all master's	14%	**19%**[2025]	+4.4 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#21	[4]
International share of STEM master's	38%	**49%**[2025]	+11.4 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#20	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	48%	**64%**[2025]	+16.3 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#25	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	47%	**54%**[2025]	+6.8 pp ▲	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#10	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	45%	**46%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#17	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	15%	**18%**[2025]	+2.5 pp ▲	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#27	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	14%	**31%**[2025]	+17.2 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#21	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	24%	**25%**[2025]	+0.8 pp ▲	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#30	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	38%	**39%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#30	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	66%	**64%**[2025]	−1.8 pp ▼	56%	+2.0 pp ▲	#8	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	53%	**54%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#22	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	42%	**47%**[2025]	+4.8 pp ▲	53%	+2.9 pp ▲	#20	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	24%	**18%**[2025]	−5.4 pp ▼	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#32	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	23%	**33%**[2025]	+9.4 pp ▲	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#31	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	19K	**23.2K**[2026]	+22% ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#16	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	1.6%	**1.9%**[2026]	+0.4 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#16	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	21%	**23%**[2026]	+2.0 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#22	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	29%	**23%**[2026]	−6.0 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#8	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	50%	**46%**[2026]	−4.0 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#19	[20]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	177	**183**[2026]	+3.4% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#9	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	9.29K	**17.6K**[2026]	+89% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#14	[20]
Active STEM master's students	4.44K	**9.54K**[2026]	2.15× ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#14	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	2.84K	**4.82K**[2026]	+70% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#12	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	67%	**64%**[2026]	−2.9 pp ▼	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#18	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	13.3K[2017]	**13.7K**[2024]	+3.5% ▲	–	–	#7	[1]
Economic contribution of international students	$722M[2018]	**$886M**[2024]	+23% ▲	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#18	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	9.04K[2018]	**8.11K**[2024]	−10% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#15	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	1.3%	**1.8%**[2024]	+0.5 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#13	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	1.1%	**1.5%**[2024]	+0.4 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#16	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	1.8%	**2.6%**[2024]	+0.8 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#11	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	7.35K	**8.8K**[2025]	+20% ▲	275K	−14% ▼	#10	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	17.9K	**17.3K**[2016]	−3.4% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#12	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	5.84K	**5.92K**[2016]	+1.4% ▲	241K	+2.3% ▲	#14	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	33%	**34%**[2016]	+1.6 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#25	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	52%	**54%**[2016]	+2.2 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#23	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	1.46K	**1.45K**[2016]	−0.3% ▼	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#8	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	48%	**43%**[2016]	−4.7 pp ▼	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#43	[9]
University R&D spending	$2.82B	**$4.65B**[2024]	+65% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#7	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	4.1%	**4.0%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#7	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	57%	**59%**[2024]	+1.9 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#14	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	12%	**8.4%**[2024]	−3.6 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#3	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	5.2%	**5.2%**[2024]	0.0 pp	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#26	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science	$91.3M	**$158M**[2024]	+73% ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#10	[6]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering	$257M	**$471M[2024]**	+83% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#15	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	28.7K	**39.4K[2024]**	+37% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#10	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state	$1.89B	**$3.28B[2024]**	+74% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#17	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state	$1.22B	**$1.84B[2024]**	+51% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#7	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state	$205M	**$350M[2024]**	+71% ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#27	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state	$1.25B	**$2.24B[2024]**	+80% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#6	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state	$1.18B	**$1.72B[2025]**	+46% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#6	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state	$422M	**$440M[2026]**	+4.3% ▲	$59.3B	+59% ▲	#20	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$39.9K[2020]	**$43K[2022]**	+7.7% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#46	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$43.9K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#49	[15]
Median debt of completers	$20.5K	**$19.5K[2024]**	−4.9% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#18	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$65.3K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#31	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$50.1K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#29	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$65.7K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#30	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$86.6K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#25	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	61%	**66%[2024]**	+5.0 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#22	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	19%	**41%[2024]**	+22.2 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#26	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$9.17K	**$7.54K[2023]**	−18% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#45	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$13.9K	**$15.6K[2024]**	+12% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#9	[4]
Tuition share of core revenue, public institutions	32%	**28%[2024]**	−4.3 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#46	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$101K[2016]	**$95.1K[2024]**	−6.3% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#28	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	32%	**33%[2016]**	+1.0 pp ▲	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#30	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	46%	**41%[2016]**	−5.4 pp ▼	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#32	[21]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT retention, master's graduates	28%	**30%**[2016]	+1.7 pp ▲	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#28	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	30%	**32%**[2016]	+1.9 pp ▲	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#22	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.81	**0.85**[2016]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#27	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	783	**924**[2016]	+18% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#13	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	77%[2016]	**79%**[2019]	+1.3 pp ▲	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#4	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**71%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#6	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**67%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#6	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	74%[2016]	**74%**[2019]	+0.4 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#4	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**69%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#11	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**55%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#3	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$44K[2016]	**$45.1K**[2019]	+2.5% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#23	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$62.5K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#24	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$55K[2016]	**$56.1K**[2019]	+2.0% ▲	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#20	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	+11.3	**+5.4**[2025]	−5.9 ▼	–	–	#11	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+10.2K	**+196**[2025]	−98% ▼	–	–	#26	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	4.1%	**3.3%**[2025]	−0.8 pp ▼	–	–	#17	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	2.9%	**2.7%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#25	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	13.6K	**20.3K**[2025]	+49% ▲	–	–	#9	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	82%[2016]	**79%**[2024]	−3.0 pp ▼	–	–	#11	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+3[2016]	**+4**[2024]	+1.2 ▲	–	–	#29	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	13%[2016]	**14%**[2022]	+1.8 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#41	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	34.2K	**29.3K**[2025]	−14% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#7	[17]

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NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	2.9%	**3.2%**^{2025}	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#7	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	91%	**88%**^{2025}	−2.8 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#3	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars	$71.1K	**$113K**^{2025}	+59% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#12	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	58%	**30%**^{2025}	−28.2 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#4	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	1.67K	**3.77K**^{2025}	2.27× ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#10	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	48%	**46%**^{2024}	−2.7 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#17	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	2.9%	**6.6%**^{2024}	+3.7 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#39	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	40%	**35%**^{2024}	−5.0 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#29	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	57%	**51%**^{2025}	−5.5 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#13	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars	$85.3K	**$96.6K**^{2025}	+13% ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#18	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	18.5K	**28.1K**^{2024}	+52% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#13	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	1.8%	**2.1%**^{2024}	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#13	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	11.6K	**17.8K**^{2024}	+54% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#13	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	1.6%	**2.2%**^{2024}	+0.6 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#13	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	1.6%	**1.7%**^{2024}	+0.2 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#12	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	1.7%	**2.0%**^{2024}	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#11	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	1.6%	**2.1%**^{2024}	+0.5 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#11	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.4%	**0.7%**^{2024}	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#18	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	3.06K	**3.12K**^{2026}	+2.0% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#12	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	3.94K	**6.18K**^{2026}	+57% ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#14	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	2.7%	**2.5%**^{2026}	−0.3 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#12	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	4.7%	**3.1%**^{2026}	−1.5 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#34	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	8.8%	**11%**^{2026}	+2.1 pp ▲	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#35	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	28%	**58%**^{2026}	+30.7 pp ▲	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#5	[13]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

NORTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	68%	**33%**[2026]	−34.7 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#25	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	267K	**452K**[2024]	+69% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#9	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	5.8%	**8.2%**[2024]	+2.5 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#15	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	16%	**20%**[2024]	+4.4 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#15	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	31%	**39%**[2024]	+7.4 pp ▲	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#12	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a doctorate	26%	**38%**[2024]	+12.2 pp ▲	47%	+0.9 pp ▲	#15	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	8.8%	**11%**[2024]	+1.8 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#11	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	6.0%	**6.4%**[2024]	+0.4 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#14	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	45%	**45%**[2024]	+0.6 pp ▲	28%	+0.7 pp ▲	#1	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	7.9%	**9.9%**[2025]	+2.0 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#21	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	12%	**16%**[2025]	+3.3 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#19	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	227K	**368K**[2025]	+62% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#8	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.92	**1.12**[2025]	+0.2 ▲	1.00	0.0	#10	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal	$82.5K	**$113K**[2025]	+37% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#18	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal	$103K[2019]	**$135K**[2025]	+31% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#12	[10]
Software developer jobs	32.7K	**58.5K**[2025]	+79% ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#7	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal	$44.2K	**$64.3K**[2025]	+46% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#29	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	2.54K	**4.33K**[2025]	+70% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#8	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	1.9%	**3.2%**[2025]	+1.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#8	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	37%	**42%**[2025]	+5.2 pp ▲	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#11	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	16%	**10%**[2025]	−5.3 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#42	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	5.2%	**1.7%**[2025]	−3.5 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#12	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	9.6%	**14%**[2025]	+4.2 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#15	[22]

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